

A WORKING REFERENCE

The Manipulation Handbook

*How influence is applied, how it is
spotted, and how it is refused*

Compiled and synthesised from the primary sources listed on the
next page. Original exposition throughout; the sources are credited,
not reproduced.

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Sources, Attribution and Purpose

What this book is

This handbook is an *original synthesis*. It is not a republication, abridgement, paraphrase-in-place, or substitute for any source it draws on. Every idea taken from a source is credited to that source by short ID tag (B1, B2, ...) at entry level and in the dossier appendix, and all prose here was written afresh for this handbook. Chapter and law titles from the sources are used only as short identifying labels.

Primary sources ingested so far

- B1** Sparkman, R. B. *The Art of Manipulation*. Cope Allied Publishing / Dial Press, 1978. Contributed: street-level tactic set (Tactics 1–14), character typologies, the financial-dealings chapter, the “unargue” method, ingratitude handling.
- B2** *The Art of Manipulation* – condensed study summary of B1 (Bookey edition, 2025). Contributed: chapter-level outline of B1 used only to cross-check coverage of B1. Treated as a *secondary* witness: where B1 and B2 disagree, B1 wins. B2 never originates a claim.

B3 Greene, R. *The 48 Laws of Power*. Viking/Penguin, 1998.
Contributed: the 48-law strategic layer, transgression/observance case structure, the “reversal” device, courtiership and timing doctrine.

The authoritative machine-readable list is `registry/books.yaml`. Adding a source is documented in `docs/INGESTION.md`; it is an append-only operation.

Why the material is presented this way

The sources describe techniques that are used on ordinary people every day, in sales, in offices, in families and in politics. A technique you cannot name is a technique you cannot refuse. Each entry therefore carries its **Counters** slot before its **Cost** slot, and the recognition material (**Tells**) is given as much weight as the execution material (**Moves**). The handbook is written to be usable defensively first.

Nothing here is advice to harm, defraud, coerce or exploit anyone. Several entries describe conduct that is illegal in many jurisdictions (fraud, extortion, blackmail, misrepresentation). Those entries exist so the reader can recognise the pattern being used against them; the **Cost** slot records the legal and practical blowback. Use this book on yourself and in your own defence.

Editorial policy on “padding”

The sources spend most of their length on historical anecdote, case narrative, repetition and moral hedging. All of that is stripped. What is kept is the transferable mechanism: what the move is, why it lands, how it shows up, how it is answered, and where it fails. Where a source’s only contribution to an entry is an

anecdote, the anecdote is dropped and the entry is not padded to compensate. See `docs/STYLE-GUIDE.md`.

How to Read an Entry

The handbook is organised by *subject*, not by book. Sources are merged into a single argument, so a reader never has to know which book said what in order to follow the text. Provenance is available on demand, not in the way.

The anatomy of an entry

Every entry answers seven questions, in the same order, and no two sections answer the same question.

- **Core** – *What is the phenomenon?* The whole entry in one to three sentences. If you read nothing else, read this. It is boxed because it must never be buried.
- **Mechanism** – *Why does it work?* The psychological or social process that causes the effect. A tactic whose mechanism you understand can be adapted; one you merely memorise breaks on first contact.
- **Conditions** – *When is it likely to work?* When it becomes weak or ineffective, and the variables that change the outcome.
- **Application** – *How does it appear in an actual interaction?* Observable behaviour and interaction structure, not theatrical scripts. Numbered and imperative. This is the slot that makes the entry useful defensively: you cannot recognise a sequence you have never seen described.

- **Feedback** – *Is it working?* The observable changes that say the interaction is succeeding, failing, or producing resistance. Bulleted, deliberately behavioural rather than intuitive.
- **Failure modes** – *How does it fail?* What makes people suspicious, what creates backlash, what makes the target disengage. Every technique in this book has a failure mode, and an entry without one is incomplete rather than optimistic.
- **Countermeasures** – *How is it recognized and resisted?* Given equal weight to Application.

Notation

- [B1], [B3] – superscript tags naming the source a claim came from. Full details in the companion Source Dossiers volume and `registry/books.yaml`.
- **Drawn from:** – the entry’s complete source list.
- **Related:** – neighbouring entries, named in full. The book is a lattice, not a line; follow the links when an entry assumes one. A link marked *planned* points at an entry reserved in the registry but not yet written.
- T-**nn-*nn*** – entry number: chapter, then position in chapter. It is printed beside every heading so citations and the source registry stay precise; you never need it to read.

Order of reading

Parts I and II are prerequisites: they cover what manipulation is, who does it, and how to read a person. Parts III–V are the technique layers, and can be read in any order. Part VI is defence and can be read first by anyone who is currently being worked on. Part VII is the cost accounting.

The Map

This book is one subject: how people move other people, how it is done well, how it is spotted, and what it costs the mover. The seven parts run in the order a campaign runs — learn the ground, read the person, take a position, make the approach, apply or resist force, and pay the bill.

The chain

- **Part I, The Terrain** — what manipulation is before anyone does it: the definitions that matter, the equipment a practitioner actually needs, the character types walking around, and the load-bearing points every person can be moved from.
- **Part II, Reading** — the intake side: motives behind words, tells that would survive a camera, listening as an instrument, and judging who you are actually dealing with before you engage.
- **Part III, Positioning** — the state you arrange before the approach: reputation, attention and scarcity, dependence, patrons and alliances, concealment.

- **Part IV, Persuasion** — moving people without force: framing and controlled choice, the appeals, demonstration over argument, delivery, and appearance.
- **Part V, Pressure** — moving people with force: guilt, fear and obligation; coercion; open conflict; and seduction, which is pressure wearing soft gloves.
- **Part VI, Defence** — the same machinery from the far side: detecting it live, refusing without winning, the money and contract traps where real losses land, and getting out clean.
- **Part VII, Cost** — what the method pays out and what it charges: the bill for using people, and the self-mastery that is the precondition for surviving your own tricks.

How the parts feed each other

Reading (Part II) feeds everything — every tell in Parts IV and V is also a detector for Part VI. Positioning (Part III) is the substrate the approaches stand on: a move made from reputation lands differently from the same move made without one. Defence (Part VI) mirrors Parts IV and V move for move — nearly every entry there has a twin here — and Part VII prices all of it, which is why its first chapter is quoted throughout the book rather than saved for the end.

Two ways through

If you are reading to defend: start at Part VI, then read Part II, then Part VII. Detection without reading skill produces paranoid pattern-matching; detection without the cost chapter

produces a person who defends against everything and falls for the thing they wanted to hear.

If you are reading the craft: read in order. The parts assume the vocabulary of the parts before them, and the entry format assumes you have read *How to Read an Entry*.

Finding things

The table of contents lists every entry by title under its chapter, and each heading carries its registry number for cross-referencing the appendix and the source files. Cross-references inside entries are written out — you will never be asked to remember what a number means.

Contents

*The list below is generated from the entry headers
(`registry/compiled/index.tex`), so it can never disagree with the body
of the book. Entries marked (planned) exist as scaffolding only: the slot
structure is in place and the writing has not been done yet.*

Contents

Part I

The Terrain

What manipulation is, who practises it, and what in the target makes it work. Nothing in the rest of the book can be used or defended against without this part, because every later tactic is a variation on one of four or five facts stated here.

Chapter 1

What Manipulation Actually Is

Definitions, and the difference that matters

Three activities get called manipulation. They differ in the lever they use, in what the target is left holding afterwards, and in how much the practitioner pays for it. The definitions below are used consistently for the rest of the book.

1.1 The Five-Percent Premise T-01-01

A minority operates; the majority is operated on

CORE. Both sources open on the same claim: the ability to steer other people is not evenly distributed. A small minority exercises it deliberately and the large majority absorbs it. The minority is not smarter. It has simply decided that other people's behaviour is a variable it may act on, while the majority treats that behaviour as weather.

MECHANISM. The asymmetry is maintained by an assumption rather than by a skill. Most people operate on a default rule — that others are broadly like them, broadly honest, and broadly acting in good faith — because that rule is cheap and usually correct enough. The practitioner suspends it. Once suspended, every interaction becomes readable in terms of interest, and reading interest is most of what the rest of this book teaches. The majority does not lose these exchanges because it is dull; it loses them because it is running a cooperative protocol against an opponent who is not. The majority also loses because much of what it does is not decided at all: a single feature of a situation — a title, a queue, a deadline — can fire a rehearsed response, and whoever produces that feature never has to meet the merits.

APPLICATION.

1. Treat the distribution as a fact, not as a grievance.
2. Assume any given counterpart may be in the minority until their behaviour proves otherwise.
3. Convert the default rule from *trust until shown otherwise* to *verify while appearing to trust*.

FEEDBACK.

- You find out about an arrangement after it has been decided.
- Your reasons for refusing are answered one at a time, patiently, by someone who clearly knew them in advance.
- You concede things you did not intend to concede, and cannot locate the moment you did it.
- The other party's stated motive changes between tellings, while your own stays fixed.

FAILURE MODES. The premise is a posture, and postures have a cost. Held too tightly it produces a person who cannot accept help, cannot be surprised by generosity, and reads every kindness as a setup — which is itself a form of being controlled, just by fear. Both sources acknowledge the trade. The usable version is situational: verify hard where money, commitment or reputation is at stake, and let the default rule stand where it does not.

COUNTERMEASURES.

- Delay. Almost every technique in this book depends on momentum, and momentum dies overnight.
- Require writing. A person working you verbally will often decline to repeat it in a form you can keep.
- Ask the interest question out loud: *what do you get if I say yes?* The answer, not the tone, is the information.
- Keep a record of your own concessions. Counting them removes the illusion that you chose each one freely.

Drawn from: B1, B3, B4

Source dossiers for this entry are collected in the companion Source Dossiers volume.

Related: *Three Different Activities*; *The Thumbscrew*; *Behaviour Over Declaration*

1.2 Three Different Activities T-01-02

Persuasion, manipulation and coercion are not the same move

CORE. Persuasion changes what a person wants. Manipulation changes what a person believes about the situation, so that what they want changes on its own. Coercion leaves what they want intact and makes it expensive. Confusing the three produces bad defences, because each is answered differently.

MECHANISM. The distinction lies in what is being worked on and what the target is left holding. A persuaded person can restate your argument and still disagree; nothing was hidden. A manipulated person acts on a picture of the situation that you edited — the alternatives, the urgency, the cost, who benefits — and acts on it willingly, which is why they do not resist and why they often defend the decision afterwards. A coerced person complies while disagreeing, and retains the grievance. That is the practical difference: manipulation buys consent, coercion buys compliance, and consent is far more durable than compliance because it does not need to be re-applied. The line between the first two is crossed without an argument whenever the edited picture is installed by a single manufactured feature rather than by a claim the target could have examined.

APPLICATION.

1. Name which of the three is in use before responding to it.
2. Against persuasion, answer the argument.
3. Against manipulation, reconstruct the situation independently: get the real options, the real deadline, the real price, from a source the other party does not control.
4. Against coercion, stop arguing about the merits and work on the cost of compliance — reduce your exposure, or make the cost of enforcing it higher.

FEEDBACK.

- Persuasion: the argument is on the table and you can repeat it back.
- Manipulation: the options, the timing or the stakes have been arranged, and you feel you chose freely.
- Coercion: the cost of refusing is stated or obvious, and the offer does not improve when you hesitate.

FAILURE MODES. The boundaries blur in practice, and both sources treat them as blurring. Selective honesty used to disarm someone is manipulation that looks like persuasion; a deadline can be real and manufactured at once. A taxonomy that is too clean makes you confident and wrong. Its use is diagnostic — it tells you which question to ask next — not verdictal.

COUNTERMEASURES.

- Reconstruct the choice set from outside. Manipulation depends on you accepting the frame; a second source breaks it.
- Slow the clock. Manufactured urgency is the most common signal that the picture has been edited.
- Ask for the terms in a form you can keep. Consent built on an edited picture rarely survives being written down.
- For coercion, do not negotiate the framing at all — negotiate the exit.

Drawn from: B1, B3, B4

Source dossiers for this entry are collected in the companion Source Dossiers volume.

Related: *The Five-Percent Premise; The Automatic Response; The Uninvited Debt*

1.3 Power as an Amoral Instrument T-01-03

The mechanics do not care what you intend

CORE. The strategic layer of this book treats power as a set of mechanics that operate whether or not you approve of them, and whether or not you intend to use them. Refusing to learn them does not remove them from the environment; it only removes them from your side.

MECHANISM. The argument is descriptive rather than exhortatory. Court dynamics — who is rising, who is exposed, who depends on whom — exist in any hierarchy, and they continue to operate on a person who declines to notice them. What the practitioner adds is attention and choice: seeing the mechanism, and deciding deliberately whether to run it, run against it, or step out of its reach. The moral question is therefore not whether the mechanism exists but what you do once you can see it, which is a question this entry does not answer and the rest of the book keeps returning to.

APPLICATION.

1. Describe the situation in terms of interest and dependence rather than in terms of fairness.
2. Identify who benefits from the current arrangement and what it costs them to change it.
3. Only then decide whether to work within it, against it, or leave it.

FEEDBACK.

- You are surprised by an outcome that several other people saw coming.
- You describe an arrangement as unfair and nobody in it disagrees, and nothing changes.

- You believe that declining to play is a neutral position rather than a move with a payoff of its own.

FAILURE MODES. This framing has a known failure mode: it makes every interaction look strategic, which is both untrue and corrosive. Most exchanges are cooperative and most people are not running anything. Held as a permanent lens rather than a diagnostic tool, it produces isolation and misreading, and the book's own later material on isolation and on the cost of using people is a correction of it. It is also a description of how power behaves, not a licence; several of the moves described elsewhere in this handbook are crimes in most jurisdictions.

COUNTERMEASURES.

- Recognising the mechanism is itself the main defence: an arrangement you can describe in terms of interest is one you can decline, price, or exit.
- Refuse the inference that because something is amoral you must be. Seeing the game clearly and playing it badly on purpose are both available options.
- Keep at least one relationship or resource outside the system you are analysing, so that leaving is real rather than rhetorical.

Drawn from: B3

Source dossiers for this entry are collected in the companion Source Dossiers volume.

Related: *The Five-Percent Premise*; *Intent Is the Only Ethical Switch*; *The Bill for the Method* (planned)

1.4 Intent Is the Only Ethical Switch T-01-04

The same move is a defence or an attack depending on purpose

CORE. Nothing in the technique set distinguishes a defender from an operator. The same read, the same delay, the same controlled disclosure serves both. What separates them is the purpose the move is put to, and the only place that purpose is visible is in what the target is left holding afterwards.

MECHANISM. A technique is a way of arranging a situation. Arrangement is neutral in the same sense that a lock is neutral: it keeps people out or keeps them in depending on which side you stand on. Learning the arrangement does not commit you to a side, but it does commit you to knowing which side you are on, because the moves feel identical from the inside. The practical test is external — whether the other person ends up better informed or worse, whether they could reconstruct what happened if they tried, and whether you would be comfortable with them knowing exactly what you did and why.

APPLICATION.

1. Decide the outcome you want before choosing a method, and check whether the method serves the outcome or merely the moment.
2. Prefer methods that leave the other party's picture of the situation more accurate, not less.
3. Where you must arrange a situation, arrange it toward a result you would defend aloud.

FEEDBACK.

- You are editing what someone knows in order to get a decision you have already made.

- You would not want the method described to the person you are using it on.
- The other party ends the exchange less able to see their own position than they were at the start.

FAILURE MODES. Intent is not observable, including to yourself in the moment. People running a self-serving move generally experience it as reasonable, and the rationalisation arrives before the act rather than after. This entry is therefore a discipline rather than a guarantee — useful because it forces the question before the move, weak because the answer it produces is often flattering. The external tests above are stronger than introspection for exactly that reason.

COUNTERMEASURES.

- Use the disclosure test: if the full method were described to the other person in advance, would the exchange still work? If not, it is manipulation rather than negotiation.
- Use the residue test: afterwards, is the other person better or worse able to look after their own interests?
- If you are the target, the equivalent question is whether you are being left holding a decision you cannot reconstruct.

Drawn from: B1, B2

Source dossiers for this entry are collected in the companion Source Dossiers volume.

Related: *Three Different Activities; Power as an Amoral Instrument; The Bill for the Method* (planned)

1.5 Results Are the Only Test T-01-05

The practitioner's epistemology, and where it fails

CORE. Both sources judge a tactic by whether it worked, not by whether it is elegant, principled or well-argued. That standard is what makes the material usable and what makes it unreliable, and it needs to be held consciously rather than absorbed.

MECHANISM. A results standard selects hard for techniques that exploit stable features of human behaviour — loss aversion, need for consistency, status sensitivity, conflict avoidance — because those pay out repeatedly across situations. It also selects against techniques that are merely correct. The weakness is structural: a single success is not evidence, and the practitioner who learns from outcomes is learning from a small, self-selected, survivorship-biased sample. The con artist's craft is genuinely well calibrated on the marks he meets often and badly calibrated on everything else. The discipline is worth adopting with the sample-size problem attached.

APPLICATION.

1. Ask of any tactic: what is the mechanism, and would I expect it to work on a person who does not share this mark's disposition?
2. Keep the failures. They are the only informative data in the set.
3. Prefer tactics whose mechanism you can state, so that you can predict where they break.

FEEDBACK.

- A method is defended by a story rather than by a mechanism.
- Failures are attributed to the situation; successes are attributed to the method.

- No one can say what would count as evidence that the method had stopped working.

FAILURE MODES. Applied to yourself, a pure results standard will eventually license something indefensible that happened to work once. Applied to others' claims, it is excellent. The asymmetry is the point: demand mechanism from yourself and accept outcomes from nobody, including the sources of this book. Both are confident in ways their evidence does not support.

COUNTERMEASURES.

- When someone justifies a method by their success with it, ask what happened the times it did not work.
- Refuse the survivorship sample: the people who were taken in are not in the room to describe it.
- Judge a technique by its mechanism, not by its testimonial.

Drawn from: B1, B3

Source dossiers for this entry are collected in the companion Source Dossiers volume.

Related: *Power as an Amoral Instrument; The Thumbscrew*

Chapter 2

The Practitioner's Equipment

What the person doing this is actually good at

Four capacities, none of them charm. Every tactic in Parts III to V degrades quickly without them, which is why most people who try this fail at it.

2.1 Affect Control T-02-01

Calm is a position, not a temperament

CORE. Whoever is more composed holds the exchange. Anger and excitement are strategically useless to the person feeling them and highly useful to the person provoking them, so the first piece of equipment is the ability to stay flat while the counterpart is not.

MECHANISM. Strong affect narrows attention and shortens the horizon. An angry person optimises for the next thirty seconds

and pays for it later; a calm person can hold the sequence in view. That asymmetry is exploitable in both directions, which is why the same source treats keeping yourself composed and making the opponent emotional as one technique rather than two. Composure also conceals information: a flat face gives away nothing about what you want, what you fear, or what you will accept.

APPLICATION.

1. Identify in advance the two or three subjects that reliably upset you.
2. Treat a rise in your own affect as a signal to stop advancing and start listening.
3. Answer slowly and below the emotional register of the question.
4. If the counterpart is escalating, let them; do not meet the register.
5. Decide the outcome you want before the conversation, and judge each of your own moves against it rather than against the insult.

FEEDBACK.

- Your voice or tempo changes when the subject turns to you.
- You rehearse a reply while the other person is still talking.
- You find yourself trying to win the exchange rather than to get the thing.
- Someone has located a subject that reliably rattles you, and keeps returning to it.

FAILURE MODES. Flatness reads as coldness, and coldness costs trust in the relationships where trust is the currency. Applied

everywhere it produces a person nobody confides in and therefore nobody tells anything to — which destroys the information-gathering half of this book. It is a tool for contested exchanges, not a way of living, and it is also the single hardest item in this chapter to acquire, because it requires the self-knowledge listed in T-04-04 first.

COUNTERMEASURES.

- Recognise provocation as information: someone is trying to move you off your plan, which tells you the plan is working.
- Buy time. Delay is the cheapest affect control there is and almost nothing in this book survives it.
- Refuse to be the one who escalates in front of an audience; the audience will attribute the escalation to whoever is louder, not whoever started it.
- If you cannot stay flat, leave. A withdrawn exchange can be resumed; a lost one cannot.

Drawn from: B3

Source dossiers for this entry are collected in the companion Source Dossiers volume.

Related: *Indifference to Being Liked*; *Vanity as a Handle*; *Master Timing* (planned); *Strategic Disdain* (planned)

2.2 Indifference to Being Liked T-02-02

The willingness to be disliked is the precondition

CORE. Most people lose exchanges because being liked is worth more to them than the thing being negotiated. The practitioner has decided otherwise, at least for the duration of the exchange, and that single difference accounts for a large part of the gap described in T-01-01.

MECHANISM. Being liked is a real asset and treating it as one is correct; the error is treating it as an asset that must never be spent. A person unwilling to spend it telegraphs that in advance, and the counterpart prices it in. Two consequences follow. First, the unwilling person cannot refuse, cannot delay, and cannot let an accusation stand unrefuted — which removes most of the defences in Part VI. Second, they over-explain, and over-explaining is itself a tell. The corollary is that retaliation is almost always a bad trade: winning an argument buys a moment and creates an enemy with a long memory.

APPLICATION.

1. Before a difficult exchange, decide in advance what you are willing to be disliked for.
2. Answer the question asked and stop. Do not fill the silence that follows.
3. Let small misreadings of you stand uncorrected; spend the correction only where it changes an outcome.
4. Refuse retaliation as a category: it converts a settled matter into an ongoing one.

FEEDBACK.

- You explain yourself more than the situation requires.
- You have conceded something in order to end an uncomfortable silence.
- You are managing how you are perceived by someone whose opinion has no bearing on anything you want.
- You let a false statement about you stand because correcting it would be awkward.

FAILURE MODES. Carried too far this produces the person nobody will help, and both sources are explicit that being needed and being trusted are assets worth holding. The usable version is selective: indifference to being liked by the counterpart in a contested exchange, not by everyone. The source that argues for meekness argues for it on effectiveness grounds — retaliation escalates and costs more than it recovers — not on grounds of contempt for the other person.

COUNTERMEASURES.

- Notice when warmth is being purchased rather than given. A counterpart who works hard to be liked is usually about to ask for something.
- Do not reward over-explanation with more pressure; it trains the other person to keep conceding.
- If you are the one who cannot bear to be disliked, put the decision in writing or hand it to someone else — a rule, a policy, a third party — so that the refusal is not personally yours to make.

Drawn from: B1, B3

Source dossiers for this entry are collected in the companion Source Dossiers volume.

Related: *Affect Control*; *Protest Too Much*; *Refuse the Argument* (planned); *The Ordered Exit* (planned)

2.3 Patience as Position T-02-03

Hurry is a tell; waiting is a lever

CORE. Apparent haste signals that you need the outcome more than the other person does, and that signal re-prices the whole exchange against you. Patience is therefore not a virtue here but a position: it keeps your need invisible and keeps the counterpart's need on the table.
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MECHANISM. Two mechanisms run together. Perceptually, hurry communicates dependence, and dependence is what the whole of Part III is about concealing. Practically, most situations have a moment at which they become cheap to move — before it, effort is wasted; after it, the opportunity has closed. Detecting that moment requires having watched for longer than the other party expected you to. Impatience collapses both: it reveals the need and it spends the effort at the wrong time.

APPLICATION.

1. Set a horizon before you start, and treat everything inside it as available time rather than lost time.
2. Match the counterpart's response interval instead of beating it.
3. Use the waiting period to gather information, which is the only productive use of it.
4. Act decisively at the moment the situation turns, and not before — standing back while the time is unripe and moving hard when it is ripe are the same skill.

FEEDBACK.

- You have raised your own offer before being asked to.
- You are checking on something far more often than its importance warrants.
- You feel that a delay is a loss rather than a neutral event.

- The other party has begun setting the pace of the exchange.

FAILURE MODES. Patience requires that you can afford to wait, and both sources note that the person with high fixed costs cannot. Waiting is a lever only for the party with the smaller exposure, which means the honest first move is often to reduce your exposure before entering the exchange rather than to sit tight inside it. Patience also decays into drift if there is no defined trigger for acting.

COUNTERMEASURES.

- Impose a deadline and see whether it holds. Manufactured urgency collapses under a request to wait; real urgency does not.
- Refuse to let pace be set by the other party's calendar. Ask for the reason behind the date.
- If you are being worn down by delay rather than by argument, name it: a tactic that depends on your fatigue stops working when it is identified.

Drawn from: B3

Source dossiers for this entry are collected in the companion Source Dossiers volume.

Related: *Affect Control*; *The Dependence Build* (planned); *Bold Entry* (planned)

2.4 Effortlessness T-02-04

Conceal the work or the work becomes the story

CORE. An accomplishment that looks effortless raises your standing; the same accomplishment with the effort visible invites inspection, envy and imitation. What is concealed is not the result but the labour and the artifice behind it.

MECHANISM. Visible effort invites two unwanted responses. It makes the result look attainable, which lowers the standing it buys you, and it exposes the method, which is the reusable part — a method others can see is a method others can copy or counter. Effortlessness also disarms scrutiny: people audit what looks strained and accept what looks natural. The discipline is therefore presentational and informational at once.

APPLICATION.

1. Show the result, not the process.
2. Rehearse until the delivery has no seams, then present it as though it were ordinary.
3. Keep your methods to yourself, including from allies who have no use for them.
4. When asked how you did it, answer at one level of abstraction above the truth.

FEEDBACK.

- You have described how hard something was, unprompted.
- You have explained a method to someone who has no need of it.
- Your preparation is visible in the delivery — notes, hedging, over-structuring.
- You feel the need to be credited for the labour rather than the outcome.

FAILURE MODES. It makes you un-teachable, which is expensive: a person who conceals method cannot delegate well, cannot build a team, and cannot be replaced — which sounds like an advantage until the workload arrives. It also isolates, since the persona has to be maintained with everyone. And it fails outright where the audience is expert; effortlessness in front of people who know the craft reads as concealment and buys resentment instead of standing.

COUNTERMEASURES.

- Ask for the method, not the result. A person who cannot or will not describe how something was produced is protecting something.
- Reproduce the work yourself at small scale. Effortlessness does not survive an attempt.
- Watch what someone does not claim credit for; the gap between visible and invisible effort is where the artifice lives.

Drawn from: B3

Source dossiers for this entry are collected in the companion Source Dossiers volume.

Related: *A Reputation You Built on Purpose; The Cutout* (planned)

2.5 Persistence Over Attitude T-02-05

Choose the animal that produces, not the one that looks impressive

CORE. A confident mood is not equipment; it fails exactly when equipment is needed. What survives failure is the decision to keep going, made in advance and executed without reference to how you feel about it.

MECHANISM. Attitude is a state and states are contingent on circumstances, so an attitude that depends on things going well cannot be relied on when they do not. Persistence is a decision, and decisions can be held against feelings. The distinction matters because the two look identical from outside during good periods, which is why people invest in the wrong one. There is also a scale error: morale that works on a group — a team, a company — does not transfer to an individual operating alone, and most of what is sold as attitude is group morale repackaged.

APPLICATION.

1. Decide the continuation rule before you start: what you will do after the first, second and third failure.
2. Judge instruments and people by output, not by presentation.
3. Treat a bad period as the expected case rather than as evidence that the plan is wrong.
4. Keep going at reduced scope rather than stopping at full scope.

FEEDBACK.

- Your confidence tracks your recent results rather than your plan.
- You cannot say what you would do after the third failure, only that you would stay positive.
- You are borrowing morale from a group you are not currently part of.
- You evaluate options by how impressive they look rather than by what they produce.

FAILURE MODES. Persistence with no review is just stubbornness, and the source that recommends it also recommends knowing when to walk away, which is the opposite judgment. The rule needs a stopping condition attached to it or it converts sunk cost into virtue. It is also weak equipment for the exchanges in Part IV, where reading and adapting to the counterpart matters more than continuing; persistence is for campaigns, not conversations.

COUNTERMEASURES.

- When someone sells you confidence, ask what they do when it runs out. A person with a continuation rule has one; a person with an attitude does not.
- Discount impressive presentation in your own assessment of people and options — the showy animal and the productive animal are priced by different criteria.
- Do not let a group's morale stand in for your own plan.

Drawn from: B1

Source dossiers for this entry are collected in the companion Source Dossiers volume.

Related: *Patience as Position; The Engagement Decision*

Chapter 3

Character Types

Who works you, and who gets worked

Two typologies, one for the operator and one for the mark. Both sources are strong here and they agree more than they differ: the same handful of dispositions produce both the successful user and the reliable victim.

3.1 The Five Dangerous Marks T-03-01

Typology of the counterpart you should not engage

CORE. Five dispositions make a counterpart expensive to work against, and they are recognisable early. The instruction is not to handle them better but to decline the engagement: whatever you hope to get from them is unlikely to be worth what they will cost.

MECHANISM. Each type defeats a different assumption. The ordinary model of a counterpart — someone who responds to incentives, forgets small injuries, and reacts in proportion — fails in a specific way for each. Pride reacts out of all proportion and immediately. Fragile self-esteem reacts slowly and indefinitely.

Suspicion misreads everything, including your honesty, and is therefore easy to fool and dangerous to be suspected by. Cold calculation waits and remembers. Literal inability to follow a scheme wastes your resources rather than defeating them. Since the failure modes are structural rather than situational, they cannot be managed by better technique.

APPLICATION.

1. Test early and cheaply, before committing anything — a story, a joke, a small favour, a small slight.
2. Read the reaction against the five patterns above rather than against what you expected.
3. If a pattern matches, withdraw while the cost of withdrawing is still small.
4. If you have already injured one of them, either settle it completely or remove yourself from their reach. Partial settlement is worse than none.

FEEDBACK.

- *Pride*: reacts violently to a slight that was minor or unintended, and the reaction cannot be reasoned with.
- *Fragile self-esteem*: no open reaction, then a long series of small obstructions you only notice in aggregate.
- *Suspicion*: assumes the worst of everyone, reads motives into accidents, and is easily led to distrust a third party.
- *Long memory*: shows nothing at the time, is cold and unaffectionate, and settles accounts later from a position of advantage.
- *Literal*: does not take a hint, does not follow an implication, and reacts to a joke or a story with flat literalness.

FAILURE MODES. The typology is a heuristic built on extremes, and applied loosely it becomes a way of writing off anyone who has ever been difficult. Most people are none of these types most of the time; the categories describe a settled disposition, not a bad day. It also carries a survivorship problem — the types are named by the people who beat them, so the quiet counterpart who simply declined to engage never appears in the list at all.

COUNTERMEASURES.

- Assume you may be the mark in someone else's typology, and ask which pattern you fit.
- Notice disproportionate reactions in yourself. They are the same tells.
- Where you cannot decline the engagement — a relative, a manager — reduce the surface area: fewer commitments, fewer confidences, nothing in writing that can be held.
- Do not attempt to deceive the literal type; the cost is wasted time, and the return is nothing.

Drawn from: B3

Source dossiers for this entry are collected in the companion Source Dossiers volume.

Related: *The Operator Profile; Do Not Offend the Wrong Person; The Engagement Decision*

3.2 The Operator Profile T-03-02

What the person working you usually looks like

CORE. The experienced operator does not present as dangerous. They present as warm, unlucky, generous with gratitude and slightly in need — a combination that disarms exactly the faculties required to notice them.
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MECHANISM. Each feature of the profile does specific work. Warmth and early intimacy accelerate the relationship past the point where ordinary suspicion operates, and they create an obligation to reciprocate. A story of former wealth explains present need without implying incompetence, which makes the request for money legible and sympathetic. Demonstrative gratitude pre-pays the emotional reward so that the target feels the exchange is already balanced. Insistence on their own trustworthiness substitutes a claim for evidence. The profile works because every element is something a decent person also displays; the difference is the concentration and the timing.

APPLICATION.

1. Watch for the profile rather than for a single tell — no individual feature is proof, and the pattern is.
2. Note where each feature appears in the sequence: warmth first, story second, gratitude third, request fourth.
3. Treat any request involving money as the point at which the profile is confirmed or dismissed.
4. Do not test them with a confrontation. Test them with a delay: the operator's response to being asked to wait is more informative than their response to being accused.

FEEDBACK.

- Intimacy arrives faster than the relationship can support.
- They were once wealthy, or once important, and something was done to them.

- Gratitude is expressed at length and in advance, before anything has been given.
- Trustworthiness is asserted repeatedly and unprompted.
- The benefit you stand to gain is restated several times by the person proposing the arrangement.
- Every story has them as the person who was wronged.

FAILURE MODES. The profile describes the small-scale operator: the borrower, the deal-maker, the plausible stranger. It is much less useful against institutional or long-relationship manipulation, where the operator has years of genuine reliability behind them and none of the surface markers. Used indiscriminately it also produces a person who cannot accept kindness, which is a real cost — warmth, misfortune and gratitude are all common in honest people, and the base rate of the profile is low.

COUNTERMEASURES.

- Slow the relationship to its natural rate. Intimacy that is refused acceleration usually reveals itself.
- Require the claim of trustworthiness to be evidenced rather than stated — references, a written agreement, a verifiable history.
- Separate gratitude from obligation. Thanks is not a payment and creates no debt.
- Keep money and personal warmth in different accounts, and notice anyone who tries to move between them quickly.

Drawn from: B1

Source dossiers for this entry are collected in the companion Source Dossiers volume.

Related: *The Five Dangerous Marks; Protest Too Much; The Reneged Price*

Chapter 4

Load-Bearing Points

Where a person can be moved from

Every technique in this book is ultimately a way of finding and loading one point in a person: an insecurity, a need, a guilt, a vanity. This chapter is the audit, offensive and defensive.

4.1 The Thumbscrew T-04-01

Everyone has one load-bearing insecurity

CORE. Every person has a single point — usually an insecurity, an unmanaged emotion, a need, or a small private pleasure — where ordinary resistance does not apply. Finding it is the whole of the preparatory work; once found, it can be loaded repeatedly and cheaply.

MECHANISM. Resistance is distributed unevenly. Most of a person's defences are spread across the areas they have thought about, and concentrated where they have been hurt before. The unguarded point is unguarded precisely because it is not experienced as a weakness; it is experienced as a preference, a taste, a reasonable

sensitivity. That is why it is invisible to its owner and obvious to an observer with no stake. Once identified it does not need to be attacked — it only needs to be referred to. A person defending a point they do not know they are defending will concede almost anything elsewhere to keep it unexamined.

APPLICATION.

1. Collect over time rather than probe. The point reveals itself in repetition, not in a single conversation.
2. Test lightly — one remark, then observe rather than follow up.
3. Note what they defend when nothing is under attack.
4. Once identified, refer to it rather than pressing it; the reference does the work.

FEEDBACK.

- One subject changes their register; everything else stays level.
- They mention the same person, achievement, or grievance far more often than its importance warrants.
- A small remark lands out of all proportion, or is deflected with unusual speed.
- They volunteer information about it unprompted, then steer away.
- Praise in one specific direction reliably produces compliance in another.

FAILURE MODES. Finding the point takes time and repeated contact, so the technique is weak in one-off exchanges, which is most

exchanges. It is also highly fallible: repetition and disproportion have ordinary causes — grief, boredom, a genuine enthusiasm — and misreading them produces confident errors. Used offensively it is the most damaging item in this chapter and the one most likely to produce the long-memory counterpart described in T-03-01.

COUNTERMEASURES.

- Audit yourself first. Ask which subject changes your register, and what you mention too often. That list is your own exposure.
- Flatten your reactions deliberately in the areas you know are sensitive, especially with someone new.
- Notice disproportionate attention to one part of your life from someone with no standing to give it. Interest that specific, that early, is reconnaissance.
- Give the point air. An insecurity that has been named aloud to a trusted person loses most of its leverage, because it can no longer be threatened silently.

Drawn from: B3

Source dossiers for this entry are collected in the companion Source Dossiers volume.

Related: *The Five Dangerous Marks; Vanity as a Handle; The Self-Audit; The Liking Handle*

4.2 The Favour Debt T-04-02

Gratitude is the cheapest lever and the least reliable payment

CORE. A favour creates an account, and both sides know it. The person who gave can draw on it later; the person who received carries an obligation that has no stated amount and no stated due date, which makes it unusually easy to over-draw.

MECHANISM. The obligation works because refusing to repay feels like a statement about your character rather than about the transaction. That is what makes it leverage: the cost of refusing is paid in self-image, not in money. It is also why the lever is unreliable — the account has no agreed balance, so the debtor can always conclude that the debt has been settled, or was never incurred, or was discharged by the resentment the giving produced. What makes it strong in the moment is that the enforcement is public: taking a benefit and returning nothing leaves a public mark, so the cost of refusing is paid in front of an audience rather than in private. What makes it weak afterwards is the same undefined balance — and an unsettled account is unpleasant enough to hold that relieving it becomes a motive in its own right. Both sources therefore treat gratitude as a poor instrument in either direction: weak to collect on, and expensive to owe.

APPLICATION.

1. Ask in terms of the other party's interest, not in terms of what you have done for them; reminding someone of a past favour gives them a reason to ignore you.
2. Keep accounts small and settled quickly, so that no balance accumulates.
3. Where you must create an obligation, make the repayment specific and immediate, which is worth more later than a vague large debt.

4. If you have done someone a favour you intend to draw on, do not mention it. Mention converts an asset into a grievance.

FEEDBACK.

- A gift or favour arrives before anything has been asked, and is larger than the relationship warrants.
- The giver mentions what they did for you, in front of others.
- You find yourself unable to say no to a small request because of a large kindness.
- Resentment appears where gratitude was expected — the debtor's way of cancelling the account.

FAILURE MODES. The debt is real in relationships that are meant to be ongoing — family, long colleagues — and treating every kindness as an opening move eventually leaves you with no one willing to do you one. Both sources accept that generosity functions as an instrument while also noting that it is one of the few instruments whose value depends on not being visibly used. The practical rule is asymmetric: be alert to accounts being opened, be relaxed about ones being closed.

COUNTERMEASURES.

- Price the favour at the moment it arrives. A specific, prompt repayment closes the account and removes the leverage entirely.
- Decline unsolicited largeness. An unrequested gift is the classic opening move because it cannot be refused without rudeness — which is exactly why refusing it politely and early is worth the awkwardness.

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- Separate the two questions: *was I helped?* and *does this request follow from it?* Most attempts to draw on the account collapse when the second is asked on its own.
 - Watch your own resentment. It is evidence that you believe you owe something you did not agree to owe.

Drawn from: B1, B3, B4

Source dossiers for this entry are collected in the companion Source Dossiers volume.

Related: *The Thumbscrew*; *The Symbols of Authority*; *The Free Lunch* (planned)

4.3 Vanity as a Handle T-04-03

Status sensitivity is the most widely distributed weakness

CORE. Almost everyone has a rank in mind for themselves, and almost everyone suspects it is not the rank others assign them. That gap is the most commonly available handle there is, and it can be worked by flattering it, by threatening it, or by appearing to occupy it.

MECHANISM. Status is the one good that cannot be self-supplied, because it consists entirely of other people's assessments. That makes the person permanently dependent on external confirmation, and therefore permanently responsive to whoever appears to be able to give or withhold it. Flattery works on the gap between self-rank and perceived rank. Provocation works by threatening the same gap. Superiority works by occupying a rank the other person wanted. The reason the handle is so reliable is that defending status feels like defending self, and people will trade material interests to do it. Reliability here is stronger than it looks: praise continues to work on a recipient who has correctly judged it to be praise. The pleasure of being approved of and the

belief that the approval was deserved are separate, and only the second is disabled by suspicion — which is why the handle survives being seen.

APPLICATION.

1. Establish what rank the person believes they hold, and who they believe confers it.
2. Address them at that rank — slightly above it in public, exactly at it in private.
3. Where you are junior, make your competence appear to reflect on them rather than to compete with them.
4. Where you must oppose them, oppose the proposal and never the standing.
5. Do not display an advantage you do not need to display.

FEEDBACK.

- They correct a minor point that does not affect the outcome.
- Titles, precedents and who-decides matter more to them than what is decided.
- Praise from the right person changes their position within a conversation.
- They will not be seen to lose, even where losing costs nothing.
- Your success in a shared domain produces a change in temperature rather than in words.

FAILURE MODES. Working the handle is easy and expensive. Status threats produce the longest-lived resentments in this book, and the reaction is disproportionate to the trigger in exactly the way

described in T-03-01, so the operator frequently finds they have created an enemy over something they did not intend to do. Flattery also has a ceiling: once recognised it converts to contempt and destroys the relationship's remaining value.

COUNTERMEASURES.

- Notice when a proposal is being resisted on grounds of who suggested it. That is status, not substance, and it can be answered by re-attributing the idea.
- Do not pay for praise with concessions. The two feel related and are not.
- Ask yourself which of your positions you would drop if nobody knew you held it. Those are the ones being held for rank.
- Where a superior is insecure, reduce visible competition rather than increasing visible competence — the second reads as the first.

Drawn from: B3, B1, B4

Source dossiers for this entry are collected in the companion Source Dossiers volume.

Related: *The Five Dangerous Marks; The Thumbscrew; A Reputation You Built on Purpose; Behave Like Others* (planned)

4.4 The Self-Audit T-04-04

Find your own load-bearing points before someone else does

CORE. The defensive half of this chapter is a short list of your own weak points, written down while you are calm. It is the highest-yield item in Part I, because every technique aimed at you must pass through one of them.

MECHANISM. Techniques do not work on people generically; they work on dispositions specifically. A person who knows that they cannot bear to be thought unfair will notice immediately when a counterpart is building a case around fairness, and that notice converts an automatic reaction into a choice. The audit does not remove the weakness — it cannot — it moves it from the automatic system to the deliberative one, which is where the counters in Part VI operate.

APPLICATION.

1. List the subjects that change your register. Use the last three months of real conversations, not a theory about yourself.
2. For each, write the request that would be hardest to refuse and the accusation that would be hardest to answer.
3. Write the pre-commitment: what you will do the next time one of these is loaded. Usually it is delay.
4. Give the two or three most serious items air with one person who has no use for them.
5. Review the list when circumstances change — a new job, a new relationship, a loss — because the points move.

FEEDBACK.

- You can name the accusation that would most upset you.
- You know which request you find hardest to refuse.
- You can identify the two or three people whose opinion of you actually changes your behaviour.
- You know what you are unwilling to have examined in public.

FAILURE MODES. Self-knowledge is unreliable in exactly the areas the audit targets, which is why the list tends to be incomplete and why the third-party check above is not optional. There is also a failure mode in over-auditing: a person who monitors every reaction becomes unable to act, and hesitation is more exploitable than any single weakness. The list should be short — five items, not fifty — and read before difficult exchanges rather than during them.

COUNTERMEASURES.

- If you are the target, the audit is the counter. Most of Part VI assumes you have done it.
- Keep a standing delay rule for any request that touches a listed point. The rule does the refusing so you do not have to.
- Ask a person who has known you a long time and gains nothing to name your most obvious one. External observers see these faster than their owners do.
- Treat sudden intense interest in one of your listed points as a boundary condition: slow down, get it in writing, involve a third party.

Drawn from: B1, B3

Source dossiers for this entry are collected in the companion Source Dossiers volume.

Related: *The Thumbscrew*; *Reading a Seeded Room*; *Refusing an Unauthorised Debt*

Part II

Reading

Intelligence before action. A tactic applied to the wrong person, at the wrong moment, for the wrong stated reason, fails and leaves a mark. This part is about establishing which of those three you are actually dealing with.

Chapter 5

Motives Before Words

The stated reason is never the reason

A request is the visible part of an interest. Working on the request is wasted effort; working on the interest is the whole discipline. This chapter is about getting from one to the other.

5.1 The Real Objection T-05-01

The stated reason is a position, not a fact

CORE. People give reasons that are presentable. The obstacle actually blocking them is usually something else — money, fear, a third party's opinion, an earlier commitment — and until it is identified, every attempt to move them is aimed at something that is not in the way.

MECHANISM. The stated reason is chosen partly to be defensible and partly because it is the reason the person can articulate. Real obstacles are frequently unarticulable: an insecurity, an obligation to someone who is not in the room, a private estimate of their own capacity. Answering the stated reason therefore produces a

strange pattern — each objection, once fully answered, is replaced by a new one — and that pattern is itself the diagnostic. A person whose real objection has been met stops generating objections; a person whose stated objection has been met produces another.

APPLICATION.

1. Stop answering objections and start collecting them. Three in a row is a pattern; one is noise.
2. Ask what would have to be true for them to want this. The answer is usually nearer the real obstacle than anything they have said so far.
3. Offer a face-saving route to the truth: make it respectable for the real reason to be money, fear or someone else's opinion.
4. Address the real obstacle directly once identified, and let the stated reasons fall away on their own.
5. If the real obstacle cannot be addressed, stop. Persuading past it produces compliance that collapses later.

FEEDBACK.

- Objections arrive serially: each resolved one is followed by a fresh one.
- The stated reason would not, if true, prevent the action.
- The reason changes depending on who is present.
- They defend the reason more vigorously than they want the outcome.
- Relief rather than engagement when you stop pressing.

FAILURE MODES. Searching for a hidden objection can become a refusal to accept no. A stated reason is sometimes the reason, and the serial-objection test is the only thing separating legitimate persistence from pressure — once the answer is a settled refusal rather than a sequence of pretexts, continuing is the coercion described in T-19-01 and not persuasion. The diagnostic also fails on the literal counterpart from T-03-01, who has no hidden layer to find.

COUNTERMEASURES.

- Notice your own serial objections. If you have given three reasons for refusing something, the fourth is being manufactured to cover the first.
- Answer the real one, not the presented one, even when doing so is uncomfortable.
- Where someone is mining your objection, give the true reason once and hold it. A single stable refusal is harder to work on than a shifting one.
- Ask for the decision to be deferred. Obstacle-mining depends on the conversation continuing.

Drawn from: B1

Source dossiers for this entry are collected in the companion Source Dossiers volume.

Related: *Follow the Interest; The Indirect Question; Concession and Retreat; A Commitment You Did Not Choose*

5.2 Follow the Interest T-05-02

Watch where the benefit goes

CORE. Ignore what people say they want and trace what they gain. In any arrangement the flow of benefit is visible long before the motive is stated, and it predicts behaviour with a reliability that no explanation matches.

MECHANISM. Interests are structural: they follow from a person's position, their costs and their income, and they change slowly. Explanations are situational: they are produced for the audience, they change quickly, and they are chosen for effect. Tracing benefit works because it reads the structure rather than the presentation. It also works reflexively — the fastest way to understand why someone is pressing you is to ask what your yes is worth to them, and the fastest way to be persuaded honestly is to ask what your no costs you.

APPLICATION.

1. For every proposal, write down who gains, who pays, and when each happens.
2. Check whether the gainer is the person explaining the arrangement.
3. Trace the money or the credit through every intermediary before forming a view.
4. Ask directly what the other party gets. The tone of the answer matters less than whether the question was expected.
5. Assume a proposer has a gain — nobody spends effort on an arrangement that does not benefit them.

FEEDBACK.

- The person proposing an arrangement describes your benefit at length and their own not at all.

- Terms favourable to you are argued for rather than simply stated.
- Someone's position changes when their incentives change, with no change in their reasoning.
- A third party with no visible stake is unusually invested in the outcome.
- The arrangement is complicated in a way that obscures who pays.

FAILURE MODES. Interest-tracing produces a cynical baseline, and the baseline is often wrong: people act from loyalty, confusion, principle and mistake at least as often as from gain. Used as a proof rather than as a question it generates confident misreadings and costs relationships. It is also weakest exactly where it feels strongest — inside long relationships, where benefit flows are diffuse, mutual and poorly measured, and where the assumption of hidden gain does the most damage.

COUNTERMEASURES.

- Trace the benefit before evaluating the argument. An argument you cannot fault from a party who gains either way is not evidence of good faith.
- Require the terms in a form that shows who pays what. Complexity that survives a request to simplify is usually doing work for someone.
- Ask what the proposer would do if you said no. Their answer reveals the value of your yes.
- Be suspicious of arrangements where your benefit is asserted rather than demonstrated by the terms.

Drawn from: B1, B3

Source dossiers for this entry are collected in the companion Source Dossiers volume.

Related: *The Operator Profile*; *The Real Objection*; *The Reneged Price*

5.3 The Black Swan T-05-03

The fact you did not know you did not know, and what it re-prices

CORE. Every negotiation runs on a picture of the counterpart's world, and the load-bearing fact of that world is often one you have not even failed to learn — an unknown unknown. When it surfaces, it does not amend the deal; it re-prices everything. Hunting for that fact is worth more than optimising inside the assumptions you already hold.

MECHANISM. Assumptions operate as if they were data. The known knowns — the case file, the stated positions — get all the attention, and over-reliance shackles a negotiator to a picture that cannot update. The unknown unknown stay invisible precisely because nothing prompts their question. They matter disproportionately because deals are structured around the counterpart's real constraint — the hidden motive, the unspoken deadline, the third party — and one surfaced fact re-prices every number built on it. Getting it out depends on two documented levers. Similarity unlocks disclosure — people trust an in-group reader — and disclosure lives in face time; it trickles in thin channels. The act of surfacing is mostly receptive — curiosity about their world beyond the deal, and the discipline of chasing surprises instead of smoothing them.

CONDITIONS. Pays most where stakes are high, the counterpart is opaque, and talks are deadlocked on positions — there a single hidden fact can break a year of stalemate. Pays least in transparent, repeated, small transactions, where the picture is cheap to verify and the swans have already flown. A counterpart who knows you hunt swans can feed you one; a fact that arrives too conveniently is bait until verified (T-23-03).

APPLICATION.

1. Before contact, write your assumptions as assumptions: what am I certain of that I have never checked?
2. Ask about their world beyond the deal — how they came to this, what else it touches, who else it must survive.
3. Build real similarity where it exists — shared background, taste, enemy — and never fake it; counterfeit kinship is worse than none (T-23-02).
4. Prefer richest-channel contact: in person over voice, voice over text.
5. When something surprises you, chase it — a surprise is the sound of an assumption breaking.

FEEDBACK.

- Landing: the counterpart corrects you gently (*actually, the reason we...*) — an assumption just died in front of them.
- Landing: warmth rises after a genuine commonality surfaces, and specifics start arriving unprompted.
- Failing: flat repetition of rehearsed positions — no disclosure channel is open yet.
- Failing: alarm at your curiosity; the question has touched the thing they are protecting.

FAILURE MODES. Faked or batched curiosity degrades the hunt into interrogation and closes the channel it depends on. One juicy fact can also over-fit: re-pricing everything on a single reveal is how a planted fact manipulates you, and the bigger the swan, the more it needs verification first. The subtlest cost is self-inflicted — a hunter in love with the hunt stops hearing the ordinary facts that were never hidden.

COUNTERMEASURES.

- Audit the other direction: what do they know about you that you have not surfaced? Your own unknown unknowns are leaking somewhere.
- Treat every volunteered *one thing you should know* as evidence, not as a gift — verify it like any other claim.
- Notice installed kinship. The in-group feeling can be manufactured on purpose, and its purpose is your disclosure (T-22-02).
- When one fact flips your whole read, sleep on it. Re-pricing is allowed; instant re-pricing is how bait works.

Drawn from: B5

Source dossiers for this entry are collected in the companion Source Dossiers volume.

Related: *The Real Objection; Follow the Interest; Posing as a Friend*

Chapter 6

Tells and Consistency

Behaviour that can be filmed

*Detection rules that do not depend on intuition or on liking someone.
Everything here is observable, repeatable, and checkable against a second observation.*

6.1 Protest Too Much T-06-01

Insistence is evidence

CORE. A quality that has to be asserted repeatedly is usually being asserted because it is absent. Honest people do not advertise honesty, solvent people do not mention solvency, and a person who keeps returning to their own reliability is managing a doubt they know is there.

MECHANISM. Two things produce over-assertion, and they are hard to separate. The first is discomfort: a person who knows a statement is false over-compensates, because the ordinary level of emphasis feels insufficient to carry it. The second is selling: a

person proposing an arrangement in which the terms do not demonstrate their good faith must supply the demonstration verbally. In both cases the volume of the claim is doing work that evidence would otherwise do. The tell is therefore not the claim itself but the mismatch between the claim's intensity and the available support — favourable terms, a verifiable history, a written agreement.

APPLICATION.

1. Supply the assurance yourself, unprompted and repeatedly, where the terms do not demonstrate good faith.
2. Attach the assurance to a moment of request rather than to a moment of information.
3. Restate the other party's benefit until it substitutes for evidence of it.
4. Increase warmth as the commitment approaches.

FEEDBACK.

- Trustworthiness is asserted before it is questioned.
- The same assurance is repeated in nearly identical words.
- Gratitude and warmth are expressed at length in advance of any benefit received.
- Your gain is restated several times by the person proposing the arrangement.
- The assurance is emotional rather than factual: tone carries it, not evidence.
- Physical warmth increases at the point where the commitment is requested.

FAILURE MODES. The tell has a high false-positive rate in two populations: anxious people, who over-explain generally, and people who have been badly treated before, who pre-emptively defend themselves. Neither is lying. It is also useless against the skilled operator, who supplies exactly the ordinary amount of emphasis and lets the structure of the deal do the persuading — which is why this test must be combined with T-05-02 rather than used alone.

COUNTERMEASURES.

- Do not argue with the assertion. Ask for the evidence it is replacing: references, a written term, a verifiable history, a small first transaction.
- Separate the claim from the deal. Evaluate the terms as though the assurance had never been made.
- Treat repeated assurance as a request to stop checking, and check more.
- Delay. Over-assertion is time-sensitive; a person selling certainty degrades visibly when asked to wait.
- Notice your own over-assertion. If you find yourself insisting on your good faith, you have already lost the position you are defending.

Drawn from: B1

Source dossiers for this entry are collected in the companion Source Dossiers volume.

Related: *The Operator Profile; Follow the Interest; The Two-Tellings Test*

6.2 The Two-Tellings Test T-06-02

Consistency across time is the cheapest honesty check

CORE. Let a person tell the same story twice, at different times, and compare the details. A true account is stable in its specifics and varies in its framing; an invented one varies in its specifics because the specifics are being regenerated to suit whatever the current purpose is.

MECHANISM. A remembered event is retrieved as a whole, so its concrete details — who was there, what order things happened in, what was said — come back the same each time even when emphasis and interpretation change. A constructed account is assembled on demand, and assembly is driven by present need; the details shift because they were never stored, only chosen. Habitual construction makes this worse rather than better, because a person who routinely reshapes stories to fit the moment loses track of what was said before. The test is cheap because it requires no confrontation and no expertise — only memory and a second occasion.

APPLICATION.

1. Ask the same question twice, separated by time, in different contexts.
2. Record the specifics the first time. Do not signal that you are recording them.
3. Compare specifics, not impressions. Framing differences are ordinary; factual differences are not.
4. Where the account has shifted, ask about the specific rather than the story, and observe whether the response is recall or reconstruction.

FEEDBACK.

- Names, dates, amounts or sequences differ between tellings.

- The story improves: each version is more favourable to the teller than the last.
- Detail density changes — one version is rich in irrelevant specifics, another is vague where the first was precise.
- The moral of the story changes with the audience.
- Challenges to a specific are met with irritation rather than with recall.

FAILURE MODES. It requires repeated contact, so it is useless in one-off dealings — which is where most losses occur. It also fails in two directions: an honest person under stress, or telling a story they were not present for, produces exactly the same drift; and a careful liar who keeps a consistent script passes it easily. It is a screening test with modest accuracy, not a determination, and treating it as the latter produces false accusations against nervous people.

COUNTERMEASURES.

- Apply it to your own accounts before applying it to anyone else's. Most people's ordinary inaccuracies are larger than they expect.
- Do not use a single mismatch as a verdict. Memory genuinely degrades and genuinely reconstructs; the test reads a pattern across several specifics, not one slip.
- If you are being tested, notice that the same ground is being covered twice and answer the second time by reference to the first rather than from fresh recall.
- Prefer documents. Where a record exists, consistency testing is unnecessary.

Drawn from: B1

Source dossiers for this entry are collected in the companion Source Dossiers volume.

Related: *Protest Too Much; The Third-Party Lie Rule; The Indirect Question*

6.3 The Third-Party Lie Rule T-06-03

How they treat someone else tells you how they will treat you

CORE. Watch a person lie to, or cheat, or dismiss someone who is not you. Their conduct toward third parties is not a separate department of their character; it is the same rule they will apply to you once your classification changes.

MECHANISM. People operate from an internal code that determines whom it is acceptable to deceive. The code is rarely organised around persons; it is organised around categories — people who matter, people who do not, people who can retaliate, people who cannot. You are currently in a favourable category, which is why you are seeing the good behaviour rather than the code. Categories are reassignable at low cost, and the reassignment happens the moment you stop being useful or start being inconvenient. Observing a third party being mistreated is therefore a direct observation of the rule that will govern you later, taken at the only time it is visible.

APPLICATION.

1. Establish a category boundary with the target — friend, outsider, adversary — and behave by category rather than by person.
2. Offer the counterpart a privileged position inside the category system.

3. Demonstrate the practice on someone else first, where the cost of demonstration is low.
4. Explain the practice as a response to how the world works rather than as a choice.

FEEDBACK.

- They lie to someone in front of you, and then assure you that you are different.
- Service staff, subordinates and strangers are treated noticeably worse than people who can affect them.
- An absent third party is described in terms that make exploiting them sound reasonable.
- Loyalty is offered as a special exemption from a general practice.
- They recount past deceptions of others with approval rather than with discomfort.

FAILURE MODES. Everyone is harsher with some people than others, and a single observation proves little; the rule reads a settled pattern, not an incident. It is also asymmetric in a way that matters — being treated well by someone who treats others badly is genuinely pleasant and genuinely unstable, which makes the observation hard to act on. Finally the rule is unavailable in exactly the situation it is most needed: the operator will not mistreat a third party in front of a mark they are still working.

COUNTERMEASURES.

- Treat observed conduct toward third parties as data about you, on a delay.

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- Reject special-exemption offers. A claim that you would be treated differently, from a person who treats others badly, is a statement about your current category rather than about their character.
 - Ask how they describe people they have fallen out with. The description is a rehearsal.
 - Assume your category will change, and structure commitments so that it does not matter — written terms, no dependence, an exit that does not require their cooperation.

Drawn from: B1

Source dossiers for this entry are collected in the companion Source Dossiers volume.

Related: *The Operator Profile; Protest Too Much; Behaviour Over Declaration*

6.4 Behaviour Over Declaration T-06-04

What a person does is the only statement they cannot edit

CORE. Words are chosen for effect and can be revised at no cost. Conduct is expensive to fake over time. Where the two disagree, the disagreement is the information — and the declaration is the less reliable of the pair.

MECHANISM. Declarations are cheap because they are produced for an audience and cost the speaker nothing. Conduct is expensive because it is repeated, observable by many people over time, and inconsistent with hidden intentions in ways that eventually show. A person can maintain a stated position indefinitely; maintaining a contradictory pattern of action is much harder. This is why the reliable reading is always the longitudinal one — behaviour

sampled across situations and across time — and why a single conversation, however revealing it feels, is weak evidence. It is also why demonstration beats argument: an action that changes someone's position without a word leaves no grievance and no counter-argument to work against. One qualification runs the other way. A stated position begins to generate its own support, so some of the conduct that follows a declaration is not independent evidence of the person's view — it is the declaration maintaining itself. Reading behaviour longitudinally is still the correct method; it simply has to discount the behaviour that a prior statement would have produced on its own.

APPLICATION.

1. Sample behaviour across at least three different situations before forming a view, including one where the person has something to lose.
2. Where you need agreement, produce a result rather than an argument.
3. Say less than the situation invites, and let your actions carry the position.
4. Where you must state a position, state it once and then demonstrate it rather than repeating it.

FEEDBACK.

- A person's stated values predict nothing about their actual choices.
- Commitments are made fluently and met loosely.
- Their account of their own conduct is consistently more generous than other people's accounts of it.

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- You find yourself persuaded by what they said rather than by what happened.
 - The gap widens under pressure rather than closing.

FAILURE MODES. Behaviour is also interpretable, and interpretations differ — a person may be unreliable rather than dishonest, constrained rather than unwilling. Reading conduct requires context that outsiders often lack, and the confident behaviourist is frequently just as wrong as the credulous listener, only later. The rule also breaks down for one-off interactions, which have no longitudinal record to read; there, structural protections matter more than any judgement of character.

COUNTERMEASURES.

- Weigh the last six months of what someone did above everything they said this week.
- Ask for a small, cheap, immediate action that follows from their declaration. Refusal or delay on something trivial is more diagnostic than any explanation.
- Track commitments in writing. The pattern emerges by itself and does not need to be argued about.
- Do not accept a revised account of past conduct as evidence about future conduct.

Drawn from: B1, B3, B4

Source dossiers for this entry are collected in the companion Source Dossiers volume.

Related: *Protest Too Much; The Third-Party Lie Rule; Concession and Retreat; Reading a Seeded Room*

6.5 The Three Channels T-06-05

Words, tone and face — and the yes that only travels on one of them

CORE. A message travels on three channels at once: the words, the tone of voice, and the face and body. People rehearse the words and not the other two, so a managed statement leaks through tone and face. A yes that arrives in the words but not in the other channels is not agreement yet — and pressing for it produces the counterfeit kind.

MECHANISM. The classical figure is 7–38–55, from studies on communicating feelings and attitudes: about seven per cent of such a message rides on the words, thirty-eight on tone, fifty-five on face and body. The arithmetic is contested; the claim that survives is that the non-verbal channels carry most of the emotional content and are far harder to script. Lying research finds the same shape: tells cluster in the unrehearsed channels. When the channels disagree, the words are the managed part and the leakage is the truth. The yes taxonomy (counterfeit, confirmation, commitment) pairs with the rule of three: an agreement re-confirmed three times, framed differently, is triply hard to counterfeit.

CONDITIONS. Strongest in face-to-face and voice high-stakes agreement, where all three channels are live and the stakes make rehearsal expensive. Weakens sharply over text, where two of three channels are gone and the check becomes the writing itself: specificity, consistency, the two-tellings test (T-06-02). Quote the ratio as a pointer, not arithmetic: it comes from feeling-and-attitude studies.

APPLICATION.

1. Watch the face in the gap before the answer settles (T-07-03); weigh the words after.

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2. Listen for the mismatch: enthusiasm in the vocabulary, flatness in the voice, agreement in the words and retreat in the posture.
 3. Summarise what they agreed to and watch the reply's channels, not its content.
 4. For any consequential yes, run the rule of three: get the same agreement three times in the conversation, each time framed differently.
 5. Over text, move the check into the record: exact numbers and dates, expensive to fake, easy to re-check.

FEEDBACK.

- Landing: the second and third confirmations come faster and more specific — commitment is real.
- Landing: a gently named mismatch (*you sound less sure than you sound*) is met with relief, not annoyance.
- Failing: the re-ask shifts the story's specifics — invented accounts regenerate (T-06-02).
- Failing: irritation at a harmless third confirmation. The yes was counterfeit and the check found it.

FAILURE MODES. Read as a checklist, the channels produce false positives: crossed arms mean a cold room, a paused answer means a careful person. Misreading leakage as arithmetic rather than evidence makes the reader confident and wrong. There is also a training effect: run the checks visibly and the counterpart learns to manage tone and face as well as words, which produces the smooth, dead consistency of a rehearsed script — the tell that used to work is now performed.

COUNTERMEASURES.

- Assume your own leakage. A yes you do not mean will show in your voice before it shows in your diary; that is the argument for not giving one.
- Separate comfort from agreement in yourself: liking someone is not a reason in the matter (T-22-01).
- When a counterpart triple-confirms your yes, notice the technique and ask which part they doubt — their doubt is the real negotiation.
- Buy time before big agreements. Leakage scales with pressure, and pressure is cheapest to remove.

Drawn from: B5

Source dossiers for this entry are collected in the companion Source Dossiers volume.

Related: *Protest Too Much; The Two-Tellings Test; The Three-Second Read*

Chapter 7

Gathering Information

Listening as an instrument

How information is obtained from a person who does not intend to give it, without the exchange turning into an interrogation.

7.1 Posing as a Friend T-07-01

Social occasions are collection opportunities

CORE. The most efficient intelligence gathering does not look like gathering. It happens inside ordinary, pleasant, reciprocal social contact, where the counterpart is cooperating because they believe the exchange is mutual.

MECHANISM. People disclose in proportion to perceived safety and reciprocity. A social frame supplies both: nobody is being interrogated, the setting is low-stakes, and the norm of mutual disclosure means that a small confidence offered first obliges one in return. Direct questioning breaks the frame and raises defences; the same information obtained inside a friendly exchange costs

nothing and leaves no residue. The technique scales because social occasions are frequent and because the collector is not required to be anyone's friend — only to occupy the position where friendship is assumed. B5 adds the delivery channel: the late-night FM DJ voice — deep, soft, slow — is credited with de-escalating a confrontational call before a single technique was applied.

APPLICATION.

1. Attend the ordinary occasions where your counterpart is relaxed.
2. Open with a small disclosure of your own. Reciprocity does the rest.
3. Embed questions in anecdotes so that answering does not feel like answering.
4. Ask indirectly about the thing you actually want, and let the answer drift toward it.
5. Keep notes afterwards, not during.
6. Use intermediaries where direct contact would be noticed.

FEEDBACK.

- Someone new takes a specific interest in your work, your grievances or your plans, without a reason to.
- They disclose something mildly damaging about themselves early, which obliges reciprocity.
- Questions arrive inside stories rather than as questions.
- They remember details you mentioned once, and use them to open the next conversation.
- The relationship has no other content — no shared task, no mutual friends, no reason to exist.

FAILURE MODES. It is slow, and slowness is fatal where the decision window is short. It also produces a great deal of low-quality material, since relaxed people mostly talk about nothing; the skill is in filtering, and the filter is expensive in time. There is a further cost the source does not dwell on: a person who habitually treats social contact as collection ends up with no social contact, which is the isolation failure described in T-03-01 and priced in T-27-01.

COUNTERMEASURES.

- Notice relationships that have no content other than conversation about you.
- Match disclosure level for level and do not exceed it. Reciprocity is a norm you can obey minimally.
- Answer embedded questions literally and briefly, then return the topic to them.
- Assume anything said socially will be repeated somewhere else, and price your remarks accordingly — especially grievances, which are the most useful thing you can hand over.
- Where a specific person keeps appearing, ask a mutual contact what the interest is. The answer is usually available.

Drawn from: B3, B5

Source dossiers for this entry are collected in the companion Source Dossiers volume.

Related: *The Indirect Question*; *Weakness as a Mask* (planned); *The Bill for the Method* (planned)

7.2 The Indirect Question T-07-02

Ask beside the thing you want to know

CORE. A direct question about a sensitive subject produces a prepared answer. The same information obtained from an adjacent question — about a similar case, a third party, a hypothetical — produces an unprepared one.
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MECHANISM. Preparation is topic-specific. A person who has thought about how to answer whether they intend to leave has not thought about how to answer what they would do if someone in their position left. The adjacent question routes around the prepared answer while keeping the underlying disposition engaged, and it does so without triggering the defensiveness that a direct approach causes. Two variants work particularly well: asking about a third party, which lets the respondent project their own view safely, and asking for advice, which invites them to state the reasoning they would otherwise conceal.

APPLICATION.

1. Move one step sideways: ask about someone like them, someone near them, or a hypothetical.
2. Ask for advice on a decision that is theirs. Advice-givers reveal their own criteria.
3. Ask about a third party's comparable situation and let them generalise.
4. Follow the reaction, not the words: hesitation and correction are more informative than content.
5. Stop after one indirect question on a subject. Two is a pattern they will notice.

FEEDBACK.

- Someone asks your opinion about a case that resembles your situation closely.

- You are asked what you would do, or what you advise, about something that concerns them.
- A question about a third party has an oddly specific shape.
- The asker reacts to your answer rather than continuing the conversation.
- Questions cluster around one subject across several unrelated conversations.

FAILURE MODES. Indirection produces indirect information. The respondent may answer the adjacent question honestly while the real position stays hidden, and projecting a view onto a third party is not the same as holding it. There is also a reciprocity cost: people who are habitually asked sideways eventually notice, and the noticing damages the relationship the information came from. The method is strongest on dispositions and weakest on facts, which are better obtained from documents.

COUNTERMEASURES.

- Notice the sideways step. When a question is adjacent to something sensitive, answer the adjacent question and not the underlying one.
- Answer hypothetically in kind: give a general view that commits you to nothing specific.
- Reverse it — ask what prompted the question. Genuine curiosity survives that question; collection does not.
- Track clustering. A single indirect question is conversation; several around one subject across time is a campaign.

Drawn from: B3, B1

Source dossiers for this entry are collected in the companion Source Dossiers volume.

Related: *Posing as a Friend; The Three-Second Read; The Real Objection*

7.3 The Three-Second Read T-07-03

The involuntary response precedes the managed answer

CORE. Between a question and its answer there is a short window in which the face has not yet been arranged. What appears in that window is closer to the person's actual position than anything they subsequently say.

MECHANISM. Answering takes work: the content must be selected, the framing chosen, the delivery managed. That work takes a second or two, and before it completes, the immediate affective response to the question is already visible — surprise, recognition, fear, relief, anger. The response is to the question, not to the answer being constructed, which is what makes it informative. Reading it requires that the question be asked directly and suddenly enough that no prepared answer exists, and that the observer be looking at the right place at the right moment rather than listening for the words.

APPLICATION.

1. Introduce the subject indirectly first, then ask the direct question once, cleanly.
2. Look at the eye region and upper cheekbones, not the mouth.
3. Read the first three seconds and then stop reading. Later expressions are managed.
4. Compare the expression against the answer. Mismatch is the finding.

5. Do not follow up immediately. The value of the read is lost if the counterpart knows it happened.

FEEDBACK.

- A micro-expression of recognition when a name or subject is introduced.
- A beat of silence before an answer that should have been immediate.
- The eyes and upper face move before the mouth does.
- Relief rather than engagement when the subject is dropped.
- An answer that does not match the expression that preceded it.

FAILURE MODES. This is the least reliable entry in the chapter and the one most prone to confident error. Expression reading has a poor evidence base in general; cultural, individual and situational variation is large; and the observer's expectations generate the readings they expect to see. The source presents it as dependable, which is not supported. Its usable form is narrow: a mismatch between a clear expression and a clear answer, on a subject you already know matters, from someone you observe often. Outside that it should not change a decision on its own.

COUNTERMEASURES.

- Assume your face answers before you do, particularly on subjects that matter to you.
- Introduce a deliberate pause before answering anything unexpected; a uniform delay is uninformative in a way that a natural reaction is not.

-
- Answer the first version of the question and let the follow-up arrive later, when you have had time.
 - Where you are watched closely, control the setting rather than the face: move, eat, face a light, involve other people.
 - Do not over-trust your own reads. You are much worse at this than you believe, and confident misreading is worse than no reading.

Drawn from: B1

Source dossiers for this entry are collected in the companion Source Dossiers volume.

Related: *The Two-Tellings Test; Posing as a Friend; The Indirect Question*

7.4 The Mirror T-07-04

Repeat the last few words and silence does the rest

CORE. Repeat the last one to three critical words the counterpart said, with upward tone, then stop. The similarity triggers an unconscious bonding response — imitation is how humans comfort each other — and the void you leave is filled by the counterpart elaborating, refining, and often correcting themselves toward the truth. It is collection with no questions asked.

MECHANISM. Isopraxism: humans copy each other to comfort each other, in speech patterns, vocabulary, tempo and tone, mostly without noticing, as a sign of bonding and being in sync. A spoken mirror re-creates that signal on demand: the counterpart hears their own framing come back and reads it as deep understanding, so they keep talking to justify it. The silence after the mirror is half the tool — people cannot tolerate a conversational void and plug it, and what they plug it with is

unscripted. Because no question was asked, nothing was conceded and no direction was disclosed; the counterpart built the picture themselves and trusts it more for that.

CONDITIONS. Strongest when the counterpart is committed to their story and you need its structure, not its summary; when asking direct questions would signal your interest or your ignorance; and early in contact, before rapport exists to spend. Weakens badly when overused — three mirrors in a row reads as mockery or obtuseness — and when the counterpart is themselves reading you carefully, in which case the technique is visible and can be named.

APPLICATION.

1. Let them finish a substantive statement. Do not nod through it; actually hold the last clause in memory.
2. Repeat the critical one to three words back with a slight upward tone — the tone of a question you are not quite asking.
3. Say nothing for two to four seconds. Let the silence do the pull.
4. Collect what comes back. The elaboration is the product; the mirror was only the pump.
5. When the flow stalls, mirror the new critical phrase and repeat the cycle. Two to four cycles is a working ceiling.

FEEDBACK.

- Landing: the counterpart expands, softens, or corrects their own statement without being challenged.
- Landing: tempo drops and personal details start appearing — a sign the guard is down.

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- Failing: the counterpart answers your mirror as a question, briefly, and goes quiet themselves.
 - Failing: they ask what you mean, or mirror you back. The tool has been seen.

FAILURE MODES. Overuse converts rapport-building into an obvious trick, and the counterpart recalibrates: if you were faking understanding, what else was performed? A mirror aimed at the wrong word — an incident, not the stake — signals that you were not listening at all, which costs more than not mirroring. Against someone trained or naturally guarded, mirrors read as interrogation rhythm and produce clipped, managed answers.

COUNTERMEASURES.

- Notice a repeated phrase coming back at you with question-tone; answer the implied question once, then ask a direct one of your own. Mirrors cannot survive direct questions.
- Treat your own words in someone else's mouth as a prompt to become briefer, not more elaborate.
- Use silence awareness deliberately: when you feel the pull to fill a pause, the pause is working on you — make the other side wait too.
- Slow, quiet speech from a counterpart mid-confrontation is a de-escalation grip, not timidity; re-assess before you relax.

Drawn from: B5

Source dossiers for this entry are collected in the companion Source Dossiers volume.

Related: *Posing as a Friend; The Indirect Question; Weakness as a Mask* (planned)

Chapter 8

Judging Who You Are Dealing With

Choosing the engagement

The decision that precedes every tactic: whether to engage this person at all. Most losses in this domain come from engaging the wrong counterpart, not from executing badly against the right one.

8.1 Do Not Offend the Wrong Person T-08-01

The cost of engagement depends entirely on who you engage

CORE. Most losses in this domain come from choosing the counterpart badly rather than from executing badly. Some people respond to being outmanoeuvred by forgetting it; others spend the rest of their lives on it, and you cannot tell which by looking at how they behave toward you today.

MECHANISM. The variance in response to a slight is enormous and is not visible from the front. Ordinary people absorb small defeats

and move on; the dispositions described in T-03-01 do not, and their response is delayed, disproportionate and sustained. Because the response is delayed, the person who caused it usually has no idea it is coming and no idea what caused it — the offence was minor, the interaction ended amiably, and the account was opened anyway. The practical consequence is that selection matters more than technique: an average move against a safe counterpart beats a brilliant move against a dangerous one.

APPLICATION.

1. Assume variance. Do not infer response type from the current interaction.
2. Gather history before engaging: how did this person handle the last person who crossed them?
3. Keep the cost of any move below the threshold at which a delayed account is opened.
4. Where you must oppose a dangerous counterpart, oppose the proposal rather than the person, and leave them a face-saving route.
5. Where you have already offended one, settle it completely and early. Partial settlement is worse than none.

FEEDBACK.

- Disproportionate reaction to something minor, especially in public.
- Coldness at the time of an injury, followed by nothing — and then, much later, by something.
- A long, detailed memory of how they were treated.
- A history of conflicts with former colleagues, partners or friends, all of which were the other party's fault.

- Warmth that arrives very quickly, before there is anything to be warm about.

FAILURE MODES. It counsels caution to the point of paralysis if taken literally, since no counterpart's response type is fully observable in advance. It also has a moral cost: a policy of never offending the dangerous and freely offending the safe is a policy of predation on the people least able to defend themselves, and both sources eventually price that. The usable version is a screening rule — gather history, keep costs low, settle early — not a targeting rule.

COUNTERMEASURES.

- Ask who this person has fallen out with, and how it ended. The answer is available and is the single most predictive thing about them.
- Do not assume you are the exception. Special-exemption claims are covered in T-06-03.
- Keep your own exposure low with anyone whose response type you have not yet observed under conflict — which is to say, with almost everyone, early on.
- If you are the person who has been offended, notice that delayed disproportionate response is expensive for you as well as for them, and settle or exit instead of accruing.

Drawn from: B3

Source dossiers for this entry are collected in the companion Source Dossiers volume.

Related: *The Five Dangerous Marks*; *The Engagement Decision*; *Total Defeat* (planned)

8.2 The Engagement Decision T-08-02

Whether to play at all, made before the play

CORE. Before technique, before information, before framing, there is one decision: whether to engage this person about this thing at this time. It is the decision that determines most outcomes, and it is the one most often skipped because it happens before the conversation rather than inside it.

MECHANISM. Engagement is not neutral. Entering an exchange commits attention, reveals interest, opens a relationship that will need maintaining, and — if the counterpart is of the type described in T-08-01 — potentially opens an account that will be settled later. All of those costs are incurred whether or not you win. People skip the decision because it is not framed as one: the exchange arrives and they are in it. Making it explicit converts a default into a choice, and a choice can be declined at near-zero cost, which no later move can.

APPLICATION.

1. State the objective before the exchange. No objective, no engagement.
2. Estimate the upside, the downside, and the cost of the relationship afterwards.
3. Type the counterpart using T-03-01 and T-08-01 before deciding.
4. Check whether the timing is yours or theirs. An exchange on their schedule is already partly lost.
5. Where you decline, decline without explanation and without insult — both create the account you were avoiding.

6. Where you engage, engage fully. Half-engagement pays the costs and forfeits the benefits.

FEEDBACK.

- You are engaged because the other person initiated, not because you decided.
- You cannot state what you want from the exchange.
- The upside is small and the downside is open-ended.
- You are engaged out of curiosity, irritation, or an inability to let something stand.
- Winning would change nothing material.

FAILURE MODES. Declining has costs that accumulate quietly: reputations for passivity, missed positions, and a pattern of conceding ground that others learn to exploit. Both sources note that non-engagement is itself a move with a payoff, and that payoff is not always positive. There is also a practical floor — some engagements are unavoidable, involving a manager, a relative, an institution — and for those the decision reduces to choosing the ground and limiting the exposure rather than declining.

COUNTERMEASURES.

- Reserve the right not to play. It is available far more often than it feels like, and the feeling that you must respond is usually manufactured.
- Answer a provocation with nothing. Attention withheld costs the provoker more than any reply, and costs you no account.
- Where you must engage, choose the ground and the time rather than accepting theirs.

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- Keep one alternative always available — another supplier, another job, another route — because the ability to walk away is what makes declining real.
 - Ask what happens if you simply do nothing. The answer is usually better than expected.

Drawn from: B1, B3

Source dossiers for this entry are collected in the companion Source Dossiers volume.

Related: *The Five Dangerous Marks; Do Not Offend the Wrong Person; The Surrender Tactic* (planned); *A Commitment You Did Not Choose*

Part III

Positioning

Power that exists before anybody speaks: reputation, attention, dependence, alliance, concealment. These are arrangements, not conversations, and they determine the outcome of most conversations before they start.

Chapter 9

Reputation

The asset that does most of the work

9.1 A Reputation You Built on Purpose

T-09-01

Others cannot see you; they see the standing they assigned you

CORE. People cannot inspect character directly, so they price you by the standing they already hold in memory and read each new deed through it. The same action reads as brilliance from one name and recklessness from another. A reputation built deliberately — chosen traits, displayed consistently — is therefore not vanity but leverage: it answers the judgment before you enter the room.

MECHANISM. Judgments run on appearances — clothes, gestures, words, visible results — because inner character is unfathomable and first-hand checking is tiring. A settled reputation spares that work, which is why it is believed. It also shields: attention fixes on the published image, and scrutiny that would otherwise reach the

person is absorbed by the file. The same mechanism is the attack surface. Seeded doubt puts its target in a dilemma with no good move: deny it and the denial itself reads as suspicious — why defend so hard? — while ignoring it leaves the doubt standing unrefuted. An attacker who already holds standing of their own can escalate from doubt to light ridicule, which signals security, puts the target permanently on the defensive, and draws attention to the mocker.

CONDITIONS. Wherever strangers price strangers: hiring, court politics, public markets for trust. Most total in small communities, where the file is shared infrastructure and one rumour re-prices the system.

APPLICATION.

1. Pick two or three traits and make every visible act consistent with them. A reputation is built by public repetition, not by assertion.
2. Treat the first doubt as an event: answer it once, early, with evidence, then stop. The denial spiral is the trap.
3. Never let the image be assigned by default. Silence lets others write the file.
4. Against a rival, sow specific doubt first; move to ridicule only from standing you already hold.
5. Keep part of the real self out of view. The published image should be the least interesting thing about you.

FEEDBACK.

- Praise or distrust that arrives ahead of any dealing — people are reacting to the file, not the person.
- An image maintained with a consistency too careful to be accidental.

- Under a rumour: either escalating self-defence or studied silence. Both responses pay the rumour.
- Ridicule of a rival from someone whose own standing is already secure.
- Standing quoted as its own evidence, with no visible works behind it.

FAILURE MODES. The image and the person diverge, and the gap must be patrolled forever: every visible act has to fit the file, a permanent tax on behaviour. Because the reputation is the asset, exposure as manufactured re-prices everything previously credited to it — the collapse takes the past with it. And the mechanism is exactly the one con artists run on: judging by standing instead of works is what a manufactured reputation exists to exploit.

COUNTERMEASURES.

- Price deeds, not names: re-read the work as if the name were absent, and see what survives.
- If you catch yourself defending against a rumour for the second time, you are paying it. One evidence-backed statement, then be seen doing the work.
- Watch for consensus about a person that everyone repeats and nobody checked — manufactured agreement is covered in T-13-01, and a seeded room is covered in T-23-01.
- Notice borrowed symbols doing the pricing — titles, offices, rooms. Ask what remains of the standing without them (T-18-02).

Drawn from: B3

Source dossiers for this entry are collected in the companion Source Dossiers volume.

Related: *Manufactured Consensus; Titles, Uniform and Trappings; Reading a Seeded Room*

9.2 Bearing Sets the Price T-09-02

People treat you at the level you act — until you pass the ego of whoever is above you

CORE. Treatment follows bearing. Ask and act at a level, and others supply the reasons for the confidence; the limits you fail to display are the limits you are not assigned. The same mechanism has a ceiling: a superior's self-image is an asset too, and visible brilliance is a claim against it. Outshine the master and the master survives you — pleasantly, with a blander replacement already chosen.

MECHANISM. Self-belief radiates like a crown. Observers cannot see the interior, so they infer from the exterior that there must be grounds: confidence is treated as evidence of competence because checking is expensive. Crown-bearers show no sense of limits, and limits disappear from what is asked and what is granted. Rebuff trains shrinking: the adult apologises for requests, pricing them small. Upward, the same display runs against insecurity. Superiors want to feel secure and superior; talent displayed beside them reads as a claim on their chair. The response is rarely open: appreciation is feigned, and at the first opportunity the sparkling one is replaced with someone less threatening. It fails two ways — by boasting, a direct claim; and inadvertently, because some masters are so insecure that unguarded excellence alone offends.

CONDITIONS. Any hierarchy: employment, institutions, courts, client work. Sharpest where one person controls your access to resources and cannot be cheaply replaced, because there the ceiling is a single ego.

APPLICATION.

1. Set the asking level before the negotiation, not during it, and remove apology from requests entirely.
2. Deliver quality quietly and attach the credit upward. Make the master look more brilliant than they are; the debt is repaid in protection.
3. Never boast to a superior. The claim is the offence; competence delivered under their flag is not.
4. Diagnose insecurity early: what happened to the last excellent person under them?
5. Where the master cannot be soothed, route around them or leave; bearing cannot win an ego war it is not permitted to fight.

FEEDBACK.

- Apologetic framing: pre-excuses, requests made small so rejection is cheap.
- A superior who praises warmly and blocks quietly.
- The bland promotion: the brilliant one passed over for someone non-threatening.
- Confidence with no visible basis, being rewarded — the room is supplying the reasons.
- A colleague made visibly smaller in meetings their own work should have made large.

FAILURE MODES. The line between confidence and arrogance is drawn by the audience, not the actor, and misreading the season is expensive: regal stiffness in a reforming mood gathers revolt, and the thrones lost to it were lost with their heads. Loom too high above the crowd and you are the easiest target on the field.

Elevating yourself by making others small forfeits the mechanism entirely — height bought that way is priced as theft.

COUNTERMEASURES.

- If you are the superior: price ideas, not deference. The comfortable candidate is not the safe one — comfort was why they were chosen.
- Distinguish confidence from arrogance by behaviour under correction, not by volume.
- Watch what a hierarchy rewards. A hall of scraped bows is a hall of shrinking ideas.
- If you are the one shrinking, the limits are self-imposed: less was asked, so less was given.
- Test the grounds behind someone's bearing rather than the bearing itself (T-23-03), and separate the person from the trappings of office (T-18-01).

Drawn from: B3

Source dossiers for this entry are collected in the companion Source Dossiers volume.

Related: *Vanity as a Handle; The Symbols of Authority; Testing a Claimed Credential*

9.3 The Inherited Shadow T-09-03

Succeeding a great name caps you at second place unless you break the course

CORE. Take over a great name's position and the great name becomes your measuring stick: what came first always reads as the original, and you as the copy. The inheritance opens doors and closes the ceiling at the same time. The escape is not fidelity to the inheritance but a visible break from it — a new course, a new base, or better, a vacuum where there is no standard but you.

MECHANISM. Judgment anchors on the first-seen standard. A famous predecessor sets the reference price for everything done in their seat, so the successor must accomplish double to appear half; every achievement is booked against what the predecessor would have done. The inheritance is still real capital — introductions, trust, machinery — which is why the seat is worth taking and the trap still closes. Breaking the course works by re-anchoring: the comparison is not won, it is made irrelevant, by denigrating the frame and moving in a direction the predecessor never set. The strongest form avoids the comparison entirely: seek the vacuum, the hollowed-out position where there is no competing star, because order restored from chaos is priced against the chaos — a standard you set yourself.

CONDITIONS. Successions of every kind: firms, titles, families, schools of thought. Weight highest where the predecessor is living and watchful, because there the anchor is actively maintained.

APPLICATION.

1. Take the inheritance as capital, not as a course. Co-opt what works; break visibly from what defines the predecessor.
2. Change direction early, while the excuse of novelty is available. A late break reads as failure.
3. Where choice exists, prefer the vacuum to the contested succession, provided you can actually supply the order.

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4. If you cannot break, change the game: compete in a field the predecessor never played, where the anchor has no readings.
 5. The shadow can also be ridden deliberately — appropriate the name to gain position, then manage expectations downward before the comparison prices you. Know which phase you are in.

FEEDBACK.

- A position where every achievement is phrased as continuation — carrying someone else's work forward.
- Introductions that lean on pedigree: the name opens the door, not the person.
- A successor doing everything right by the predecessor's book and quietly underperforming anyway.
- Institutions where the founder out-performs every incumbent. The seat is priced, not the person.

FAILURE MODES. The break wastes real capital: the name is introductions and trust, and denigrating it reads as ingratitude to the constituency that came with the seat. The vacuum play assumes you can govern what you found; order that fails to arrive is chaos with your name on it. And the pivot is timing-bound — early it is vision, late it is confession.

COUNTERMEASURES.

- If you hold the great name: choose the successor who will break course, and protect them while they do it. Enforced fidelity is the quieter failure.
- Evaluate successors on the course they set, not the continuity they preserve.

- Beware vacuum pitches. Chaos is an opportunity only for whoever can supply order; audit the order, not the ambition.
- When someone trades wholly on an inherited legend, expect the discard and ask what remains of them when the name is spent (T-22-02).

Drawn from: B3

Source dossiers for this entry are collected in the companion Source Dossiers volume.

Related: *A Reputation You Built on Purpose; Bearing Sets the Price; Borrowed Warmth*

Chapter 10

Attention, Absence and Scarcity

Value as a function of availability

10.1 Value as a Function of Availability

T-10-01

The rarer a thing appears, the more it is worth

CORE. Opportunities look more valuable when they look less available. The judgement is about scarcity rather than about the thing, so scarcity can be produced and the value follows it without the object changing at all.

MECHANISM. Scarcity carries information. A thing that is hard to obtain has usually survived some test — of demand, of difficulty, of selection — and treating rarity as a proxy for quality is normally a reasonable shortcut. It is also a shortcut about loss rather than about gain: as availability falls, what is at stake

changes from acquiring something to avoiding the loss of an option, and loss weighs more heavily than the equivalent gain.

That is what makes the proxy exploitable. Availability is a claim about the world that can be manufactured more cheaply than the condition itself — a number can be limited, a date can be set, a supply can be described as failing. Nothing about the object has to change. And because the resulting pressure is experienced as an appraisal of value rather than as a reaction to a deadline, the target does not notice that the judgement has been moved.

APPLICATION.

1. Limit the number, the window or the eligibility, and make the limit visible before the request.
2. Describe the limit as a fact about the world rather than as a decision you made.
3. Frame the offer as an option that will disappear rather than as a thing that can be acquired.
4. Withdraw access gradually so that each stage reads as a real reduction.

FEEDBACK.

- Your estimate of what the thing is worth rose when you learned how little of it there is.
- Availability is stated but never evidenced.
- The scarcity arrived at the moment a decision was required.
- You are competing for access rather than evaluating the thing.
- Losing the option feels worse than the thing feels good.

FAILURE MODES. Manufactured scarcity is the easiest of the techniques to expose and the most damaging once exposed, because a limit that moves on request was never a limit. It also selects badly: people who respond most strongly to scarcity are frequently the worst customers, since the pressure that brought them produces regret shortly afterwards. And habitual exposure to it degrades the practitioner's own judgement — someone who always works under artificial deadlines stops being able to tell an urgent thing from a merely announced one.

COUNTERMEASURES.

- Ask what the thing is worth when it is plentiful. If the answer changes with the count, you were never evaluating the thing.
- Establish the base rate: how often has this been scarce, and did the scarcity pass without consequence last time?
- Separate use from possession. Scarcity inflates the value of owning an option, which is usually not what you actually want.
- Check whether the limit is real by trying to exceed it.
- Delay past the deadline and observe whether the deadline moves.

Drawn from: B4

Source dossiers for this entry are collected in the companion Source Dossiers volume.

Related: *The Reactance Trigger; Limited Numbers and Deadlines; The Contrast Principle; Refusing a Deadline*

10.2 The Reactance Trigger T-10-02

A threatened freedom is defended out of proportion to its value

CORE. When a freedom is limited, people want it more than they wanted it before, and want whatever it gave them access to more than they valued it before. The reaction is against the restriction, not in favour of the thing — which is why it produces value that was never there.

MECHANISM. The mechanism is a defence of the range of options rather than of any particular option. A person who loses an ability loses part of their control over their own circumstances, and control is defended disproportionately because it underwrites everything else.

Three properties follow, and they are what make the trigger usable. First, the escalation is real but displaced: the thing becomes more desired because it is the site of the lost freedom, and the desire survives the loss. Second, the trigger is most powerful where the freedom was already held and is then removed — a restriction on something never permitted produces far less than a restriction on something previously ordinary. Third, the reaction is intensified by competition: scarcity that is also contested combines the loss of an option with the presence of a rival, and both fire at once.

The practical consequence is that withdrawal works better than refusal. Take something away and it is defended; never offer it and it is not missed.

APPLICATION.

1. Grant a freedom and then withdraw it, rather than refusing it from the start.
2. Withdraw gradually, so each stage is felt as a new loss.

3. Introduce competition for what remains.
4. Frame the restriction as imposed by circumstance rather than chosen by you — an externally caused loss is still defended, and the defender does not turn on you.

FEEDBACK.

- You want the thing more since it became harder to get.
- The restriction arrived after the freedom was established.
- Others are competing for the same limited thing.
- Your objection is to being restricted rather than to the substance.
- You cannot say what you would do with the thing if you had it.

FAILURE MODES. Deliberately withdrawing a freedom to generate desire is the point at which this stops being persuasion, and the counterpart usually knows it — the feeling of being managed is distinctive and is rarely forgiven. It also produces compliance of a particular bad kind: the person obtains the thing and immediately loses interest, because what they wanted was the freedom rather than the object. That is a poor outcome for a seller, a worse one for a partner, and worst of all when turned inward, where a person who restricts themselves to manufacture motivation ends up wanting nothing they can actually have.

COUNTERMEASURES.

- Ask what the thing was worth before it was restricted. That is still its worth; the increase belongs to the restriction.
- Identify which freedom you are actually defending, and check whether the thing on the table is what that freedom was for.

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- Notice competition and discount it. A rival increases the price without increasing the value.
 - Test by accepting the restriction. If the desire falls away rather than intensifying once you stop resisting, it was reactance and not preference.
 - Ask who benefits from your defending this particular freedom.

Drawn from: B4

Source dossiers for this entry are collected in the companion Source Dossiers volume.

Related: *Value as a Function of Availability; Limited Numbers and Deadlines; Refusing a Deadline; Total Defeat* (planned)

10.3 Limited Numbers and Deadlines T-10-03

The two forms scarcity is delivered in

CORE. Scarcity reaches a person in two standard forms: a limited quantity and a closing date. Both are announcements about the world that can be made without changing anything in it, and both work hardest when they arrive together and suddenly.

MECHANISM. A limited quantity works through competition. The number is not only a constraint but a signal that others want the thing, which imports crowd evidence into the scarcity and doubles its force — the object is rarer and independently confirmed as desirable.

A deadline works through the loss of the option to decide later. Postponement is the ordinary answer to a difficult judgement, because more information usually arrives; a closing date removes that answer and forces a decision under exactly the conditions of

ambiguity in which shortcuts are followed most readily. The deadline does not make the thing more valuable. It makes the decision worse, and a worse decision is an easier one to steer.

Novelty strengthens both. A scarcity that has just appeared is more alarming than one that has always been there, because the change implies information you do not have. The announcement therefore matters more than the condition. One room left, nine people viewing it, a rate expiring at midnight: three instruments, not three facts.

APPLICATION.

1. Announce the limit before the request, with a specific number or date rather than a general warning.
2. Present the scarcity as recent. A change implies information and is more alarming than a standing condition.
3. Combine quantity and deadline, and let each confirm the other.
4. Make the competition visible; the number works harder when other claimants can be seen.

FEEDBACK.

- A quantity or a date is stated with precision and no explanation.
- Both arrive together.
- The scarcity is new, and its newness is emphasised.
- You are deciding under time pressure about something you would normally take a day over.
- Others are visibly competing for the same limited thing.

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- The announcement serves the seller more than it informs you.

FAILURE MODES. Both forms are cheap to falsify and therefore cheap to detect. A deadline that passes and returns, or a final unit that is followed by another, tells the customer everything about the seller at once — and the discovery is more damaging than the extra sale was worth. Used honestly, both are simply information about real constraints, and the honest version has most of the effect at none of the cost, which is the strongest argument for it.

COUNTERMEASURES.

- Ask when the limit was set and by whom. A limit the seller chose is an instrument, not a fact.
- Check the history. If the same deadline has passed before without consequence, it is not a deadline.
- Separate the two claims: is the thing scarce, and is it desirable? Answer each without reference to the other.
- Remove the time pressure and see whether the judgement survives. A decision that only works inside the window was never about the object.
- Ask for the terms in writing, dated, with the limit stated. Manufactured limits are usually unwilling to be written down.

Drawn from: B4

Source dossiers for this entry are collected in the companion Source Dossiers volume.

Related: *Value as a Function of Availability; The Reactance Trigger; Refusing a Deadline; The Crowd as Evidence*

Chapter 11

Dependence

Being needed is a structure, not a sentiment

Entries in this chapter are not yet written. The scaffolding is in place; see the State of the Build appendix for what is outstanding.

Chapter 12

Alliances, Patrons and Courts

Where you stand, and who you stand with

Entries in this chapter are not yet written. The scaffolding is in place; see the State of the Build appendix for what is outstanding.

Chapter 13

Concealment and Indirection

Acting through what is not shown

13.1 Manufactured Consensus T-13-01

Building the appearance of agreement without the agreement

CORE. Consensus can be assembled rather than earned. Seeded audiences, planted questions, staged applause, selected testimonials and controlled comment sections all produce the appearance of general agreement, and the appearance is what does the persuading.

MECHANISM. The construction works because agreement is normally inferred from its visible traces rather than measured directly. Nobody counts believers; people read the room. So the room is what gets built.

Three properties make the construction cheap. It needs only a minority of participants, since the rest supply themselves by

copying. It needs no coordination among them, since each takes their cue from what is displayed. And it needs no persistence, since the inference is drawn at the moment of decision and the room can be different an hour later. What is required is control of what is visible at that moment — which is why the technique concentrates on venues, formats and channels rather than on arguments.

APPLICATION.

1. Control the venue. A format in which only agreement is visible is worth more than an argument.
2. Seed early and visibly; the first few set the direction the rest copy.
3. Have supporters answer dissent rather than answering it yourself — peer correction is more persuasive and costs you nothing.
4. Aggregate. Counts, percentages and rankings conceal their own composition.
5. Time the display to the decision, not to the discussion.

FEEDBACK.

- Agreement is unanimous and unexplained.
- The supporters appear in the same place and at the same time.
- Dissent is absent, filtered, or answered by other audience members rather than by the presenter.
- The supporting voices are anonymous, aggregated or newly created.

- You cannot name a single person who holds the view and is not part of the presentation.

FAILURE MODES. The construction is discoverable and, once discovered, discredits everything around it — including the parts that were genuine. It also selects for the wrong kind of supporter: people willing to perform agreement are usually available to whoever pays, so a manufactured consensus is an asset that can be bought away from you. And because it substitutes for argument, it leaves the underlying case unmade, which matters the first time the audience changes.

COUNTERMEASURES.

- Leave the venue. Take the question somewhere the room was not built — a different channel, a different audience, a private conversation.
- Ask for names. A consensus that will not resolve into individuals is a presentation.
- Look at what was excluded rather than at what was shown. Ask what would have to be filtered out for the room to look like this.
- Check the timestamps. A consensus that appeared all at once was built all at once.
- Hold your own view privately before entering, and treat any movement as something requiring an explanation.

Drawn from: B4

Source dossiers for this entry are collected in the companion Source Dossiers volume.

Related: *The Crowd as Evidence; Uncertainty and Similarity; Reading a Seeded Room; Weakness as a Mask* (planned)

Part IV

Persuasion

Moving a mind without moving a muscle. Framing, appeal, demonstration, delivery. The cheapest and most reversible instruments in the book, and therefore the ones worth mastering first.

Chapter 14

Framing and Controlled Choice

Dealing the cards the other person plays

14.1 The Automatic Response T-14-01

A single cue can fire a whole routine

CORE. Most compliance is not decided. A salient feature of the situation — a title, a queue, a deadline, a small gift — fires a rehearsed response that runs without the substance being evaluated. Whoever produces the feature steers the response and never has to win an argument.

MECHANISM. The routine exists because evaluating everything is unaffordable. Judging a request on its merits takes attention, information and time; most requests are ordinary, so a shortcut is normally correct. The shortcut is to find one feature that reliably predicts the whole and respond to the feature rather than to the thing.

That is efficient, and it is precisely what makes it exploitable: the feature can be manufactured far more cheaply than the condition it stands for. A credential is faster to fake than to earn, a crowd faster to assemble than to convince, a deadline faster to announce than to meet. Every principle in the rest of this book is a case of a predictable feature being produced on purpose, and the target's error is never stupidity — it is that the shortcut was correct often enough to be worth keeping. B5 restates the architecture as negotiation's premise: under pressure the fast, emotional system answers first and the deliberate system arrives late — whoever calms the fast system owns the move. The same words on letterhead are read differently from the same words on a napkin, and the difference survives knowing perfectly well that letterhead costs nothing to print.

APPLICATION.

1. Identify the one feature you intend the other party to respond to, and make sure it is present before you make the request.
2. Ask what it would cost you to fake that feature. If the answer is little, expect the other party to have faked it.
3. Make your own cues expensive to counterfeit: a verifiable record, a named reference, a real queue. A cue that cannot be borrowed cannot be stolen.

FEEDBACK.

- You notice yourself agreeing before you have finished hearing the request.
- Your reason for saying yes is a single feature — the letterhead, the logo, the queue — rather than a weighing.

- The feature you relied on is cheap to produce and expensive to verify.
- Asked afterwards to reconstruct the decision, you cannot.

FAILURE MODES. The shortcut is not a defect and cannot be removed without cost. A person who evaluates every cue from first principles cannot hire anyone, buy anything or cross a street, and is still wrong about most things — only slower and more exhausting about it. The usable rule is asymmetric: keep the shortcuts where being wrong is cheap, and treat cheap-to-fake cues as worthless exactly where it is not. The entry's epilogue case is that the volume of cues now arriving per hour has risen while the time to evaluate each has fallen, which moves more decisions into the first category whether or not anyone intends it.

COUNTERMEASURES.

- Separate the cue from the claim, and ask the question the cue was answering in terms the cue cannot answer.
- Delay. Automatic routines depend on momentum, and momentum does not survive an hour.
- Price the cue. Anything cheap to produce and hard to verify carries no information and should be discounted to zero.
- Name the routine to yourself while it is running.
Recognising a shortcut in use is most of disabling it.

Drawn from: B4, B5

Source dossiers for this entry are collected in the companion Source Dossiers volume.

Related: *The Contrast Principle; The Five-Percent Premise; The Symbols of Authority; Reading a Seeded Room*

14.2 The Contrast Principle T-14-02

A second option is judged against the first, not on its own

CORE. Judgements are comparative. The same price, the same request and the same concession are evaluated differently depending on what was presented immediately before, so whoever chooses the order of presentation chooses a good part of the verdict.

MECHANISM. There is no absolute scale available for most decisions. What counts as a fair price, a large favour or a serious problem is not knowable in isolation, so the mind settles it by comparison with whatever was most recently in view. That makes the first item a measuring instrument rather than a candidate: it is frequently not meant to be accepted at all, and its function is to set the distance against which the second item looks small.

The principle is not confined to price. Severity, urgency and generosity all take their scale from the immediately preceding case, which is why an offer can be made to look reasonable without changing the offer — only what precedes it. The control lies entirely with the party who decides the sequence. An agent who shows two unsuitable properties before the one she means to let has not wasted an afternoon; she has built the ruler the third will be measured against.

APPLICATION.

1. Set the anchor deliberately, and let it introduce the proposal you actually want accepted.
2. Present the expensive case first whenever the cheap case has to be accepted on its own terms.
3. Move in visible steps rather than arriving at your real position immediately; a position reached by stages is judged against the stages.

FEEDBACK.

- Two or more options arrive in a fixed order, and the first is described at length and then abandoned without any effort to sell it.
- You find the second option reasonable and cannot say what you are comparing it against.
- The comparison set is supplied entirely by the other party.
- An item you would have refused a week ago now looks modest.

FAILURE MODES. Anchoring is so ordinary that using it deliberately changes little in most transactions, and refusing to be anchored at all makes you slower and more suspicious than the situation calls for. The exposure worth guarding is narrow: it is where the anchor is far from the truth and the other party controls the entire comparison set. That is why the defence is to bring a comparison in from outside rather than to argue about the one on offer — arguing inside a frame accepts the frame.

COUNTERMEASURES.

- Ask for the options out of order, or for each one separately.
- Import your own comparison. Price the thing against the market, not against the alternative on the table.
- Evaluate the final proposal as though it were the first thing you had heard, which is what it would have been in an honest sequence.
- Notice the abandoned first option. An offer presented at length and then dropped without argument was probably never for sale.

Drawn from: B4

Source dossiers for this entry are collected in the companion Source Dossiers volume.

Related: *The Automatic Response; The Crowd as Evidence; The Reneged Price*

14.3 The Small First Yes T-14-03

A commitment escalates on its own fuel

CORE. A person who has agreed to something small will agree to something much larger in the same direction, at a rate the larger request would not achieve on its own. The first agreement is not a step toward the second; it is what makes the second look like the same decision continued.

MECHANISM. Consistency is treated as a virtue and as evidence of a settled character, so once a position has been taken the pressure to hold it is partly social and partly internal. The useful consequence is that the position begins to generate its own support.

After agreeing, a person assembles reasons for having agreed, notices evidence they would previously have ignored, and adopts a self-description that the agreement implies. Those new reasons survive the removal of the original inducement, which is the whole point: the structure holds itself up after the scaffolding is taken away. A small request is therefore valuable in proportion to how far the self-description it implies extends, not in proportion to what it costs.

APPLICATION.

1. Ask for the smallest commitment that still implies the self-description you want installed.

2. Let the counterpart state the reason for agreeing. Their reason is more durable than yours and is not withdrawn when you leave.
3. Escalate gradually and always in the same direction; a lateral move reads as a new request and reopens the decision.
4. Remove the inducement once the position is taken, so that what remains is supported only by the counterpart's own reasons.

FEEDBACK.

- The first request is trivially small and framed as though it settles nothing.
- Agreeing to it implies a self-description you would not have offered unprompted.
- A larger request follows in the same direction and is presented as continuous with the first.
- You find yourself producing reasons for the position that were not present when you took it.
- Refusing the second request would require explaining the first.

FAILURE MODES. The technique produces compliance that is durable but shallow: the counterpart holds the position because they have built reasons for it, and those reasons collapse abruptly if the escalation is ever named. Being caught manufacturing a commitment loses the relationship rather than the single transaction, which is a poor trade where you will meet the person again. Used on yourself in reverse it is legitimate — a small public commitment to something you actually want to do is one of the few reliable self-management tools there is.

COUNTERMEASURES.

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- Treat every request as the first one. Ask whether you would agree to it having never agreed to anything before.
 - Separate the two questions: what did I commit to, and what is now being asked? Small agreements are frequently presented as though they covered more ground than they did.
 - Watch for reasons you have acquired since agreeing. New justifications appearing after a decision are usually the decision defending itself.
 - Allow yourself to change your mind on new information. The charge of inconsistency is only a cost if you accept that consistency is itself the virtue being tested.

Drawn from: B4

Source dossiers for this entry are collected in the companion Source Dossiers volume.

Related: *The Automatic Response; The Four Amplifiers; Behaviour Over Declaration; A Commitment You Did Not Choose*

14.4 The Four Amplifiers T-14-04

Written, active, public and effortful commitments bind hardest

CORE. Not all commitments hold equally. Four properties strengthen one: it is written down, it was performed rather than assented to, other people saw it, and it cost something to make. Each can be designed for, and each makes the commitment harder to abandon than its content warrants.

MECHANISM. Writing supplies a record the person cannot later re-describe, and the act of writing is itself a small piece of authorship — the position stops being something heard and

becomes something produced. Action binds more than assent because a performed behaviour is evidence about the self, whereas agreement is only evidence about a conversation. Publicity adds an audience whose expectations are now part of the cost of reversal, and makes the commitment a statement of identity rather than of preference. Effort is the strongest of the four because the person must justify the cost they paid, and the cheapest justification available is that they wanted to pay it.

The four compound. A commitment that is all four is close to unbreakable from inside, which is why institutions that need reliable allegiance arrange all four rather than any one.

APPLICATION.

1. Get it in the counterpart's own handwriting wherever possible, even for something trivial.
2. Arrange for them to act before they decide, so the decision follows the behaviour.
3. Introduce an audience early, and let the counterpart make the announcement themselves.
4. Invest their effort visibly. Effort they can see is effort they must account for.

FEEDBACK.

- You are asked to sign, initial, fill in or write out the agreement yourself rather than receive it complete.
- You perform something before you have decided — a trial, a configuration, an assessment, a visit.
- The commitment is announced to others, or others are invited to witness it.

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- Considerable time, money or effort has already been spent, and leaving would forfeit it.
 - Refusing now would require explaining yourself to people who already know you agreed.

FAILURE MODES. Amplifying a commitment you do not fully control is dangerous in both directions. The same properties that bind a counterpart bind you: a public written position of your own is expensive to revise, and people who design these structures usually find themselves inside one. There is also a straightforward honesty cost — a commitment extracted by engineering its amplifiers is not the counterpart's commitment, and discovering that is the end of the relationship rather than of the deal.

COUNTERMEASURES.

- Decline to write, sign or perform anything before the decision is made. Ask for the terms complete, in their hand, not yours.
- Keep commitments private until they are settled. An audience converts a preference into an identity claim.
- Treat sunk effort as spent rather than as a reason. Ask what you would do if the effort had never been spent.
- Reverse in writing. A written commitment is answered by a written withdrawal, which restores symmetry and removes the record's advantage.

Drawn from: B4

Source dossiers for this entry are collected in the companion Source Dossiers volume.

Related: *The Small First Yes; Behaviour Over Declaration; A Commitment You Did Not Choose; The Reneged Price*

14.5 The Label T-14-07

Name the emotion and it loses the steering wheel

CORE. State the counterpart's emotion or stake as an observation — some variant of *it seems like* or *it sounds like* — and never as a question about them. Naming an emotion moves the counterpart from feeling it to confirming or correcting your description; either way they are now processing it, not obeying it.

MECHANISM. An unlabelled emotion runs the person; a labelled one becomes an object of joint attention. The label works because it requires no confession: the counterpart can accept it silently, deny it, or refine it, and every path yields information while the framing stays theirs. Used on fear or anger, it defuses — the counterpart hears their worst case said aloud without catastrophe following. Used on positives, it reinforces them. The pre-emptive form, the accusation audit, lists every negative the counterpart could think about you before they do: each accusation, spoken first by you, arrives with no defence attached and therefore disarms as mere fact.

CONDITIONS. Strongest under visible emotion — fear, anger, resentment, suspicion — and at the start of high-stakes contact, where the audit variant belongs. Weakest against flat, professional counterparts who feel nothing in play, where the label is just noise; and in cultures or relationships where naming feelings reads as intrusion, it costs more than it buys. Mislabelling is the operational risk: a wrong label tells the counterpart you do not understand them at all.

APPLICATION.

1. Infer the emotion from what they do, not what they say: hostages in a siege worry about dying and prison whether or not they mention it.

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2. Open with the two least threatening words — *it seems like* — and name the stake: the fear, the constraint, the position you suspect they hold.
 3. Stop. Let them confirm, correct, or deny. Every response is intelligence.
 4. Re-label as the emotion moves. A label is a probe, not a verdict.
 5. For the audit form, open with the worst they could say about you — *you're going to think I'm unreasonable, and you have no reason to trust me* — and pause. Let them waive it.

FEEDBACK.

- Landing: they answer the label's content — *exactly*, or *no*, *the real issue is...* — and the temperature drops.
- Landing on an audit: the counterpart dismisses the accusation and often volunteers reassurance, which reverses the frame.
- Failing: flat agreement with no elaboration, or a fast *don't tell me how I feel*.
- Failing: they begin labelling you back — the mirror has been raised.

FAILURE MODES. A wrong label tells the counterpart you were performing understanding, and performance is worse than silence: it converts sympathy into suspicion. Labels used mechanically — sprinkled to steer — read as therapy-script handling, and the counterpart feels managed rather than met. The audit overdone sounds like a con man's rehearsed humility; two or three honest negatives outperform six polished ones.

COUNTERMEASURES.

- Notice the form: *it seems like* almost never precedes a genuine request for your view; it precedes steering. Treat the label as a probe and answer with facts, not feelings.
- Refuse the frame politely: name what they are doing — *you're labelling me* — and the tool is spent.
- When someone pre-lists your criticisms of them, ask yourself why they needed you not to hold them; the audit itself is the information.
- Keep your own stakes spoken plainly. Labels feed on the unsaid.

Drawn from: B5

Source dossiers for this entry are collected in the companion Source Dossiers volume.

Related: *Borrowed Warmth; The Uninvited Debt; Manufactured Rapport*

14.6 The Calibrated Question T-14-08

Make the other side solve your problem

CORE. Ask open *how* and *what* questions that hand the counterpart your problem as if it were theirs — *how am I supposed to do that?*, *what about this works for you?* — and never *why*, which accuses. The question removes aggression while moving the frame: the counterpart answers, and in answering starts solving on your terms, feeling in control the whole time.

MECHANISM. A calibrated question is an offer of agency with the direction built in. Open-ended how/what questions engage the counterpart in generating the solution, so the outcome is partly authored by them — the illusion of control is the point: people defend what they feel they chose. Demands trigger resistance; the

same content as a question triggers collaboration, which is why the source calls it a way to introduce ideas and requests without sounding pushy — a nudge that carries no visible push. *Why* is excluded because it assigns blame regardless of intent. The polite-impossible form — *how am I supposed to do that?* — is a refusal in the grammar of cooperation: it forces the counterpart to solve your impossibility or lower their demand.

CONDITIONS. Strongest against aggressive or positional counterparts, in asymmetric-power talks where a direct no is expensive, and mid-conflict where a demand would escalate. Weakens with counterparts who will not think — the question needs an interlocutor — and under time pressure where a decision, not a dialogue, is required; overuse turns every exchange into therapy and the counterpart notices they are being steered by questions.

APPLICATION.

1. Convert your next demand into *how* or *what*: not *you need to lower the price* but *how am I supposed to take this to my side?*
2. Map the field before answering theirs: *what is your objective here? what about this is important to you?*
3. For the impossible ask, use the polite-impossible: *how am I supposed to do that?* — sincere tone, genuine puzzle.
4. Stack questions; never stack demands. Each answer should pull the next question into reach.
5. Save *why* for genuine curiosity about the past, never for their present behaviour.

FEEDBACK.

- Landing: the counterpart starts designing within your constraint — their answer contains your terms.

- Landing: tone de-escalates measurably; they begin asking *we* questions.
- Failing: *just figure it out* — they decline the authorship; fall back to labels (T-14-07) before re-asking.
- Failing: they answer your how-question with a question of their own; two steering systems are now running — decide whose field you are on.

FAILURE MODES. Detected, the pattern reads as manipulation-by-questions, and the counterpart feels managed exactly when they believed they were choosing — the backlash is colder than a refused demand. It also fails as deflection: a question that only stalls, without accepting any answer, is visible within two rounds. And chronic use atrophies the direct ask; some moments need a stated position, and a person who only ever questions becomes a person who cannot be negotiated with.

COUNTERMEASURES.

- Notice you are being asked how *you* will solve *their* problem; answer once, then ask what they are bringing.
- Return the question with its frame exposed: *that's a fair question — here's my constraint; what's yours?*
- Refuse the authorship trap: do not design inside their constraint. *That's your number to solve* is a complete answer.
- Track why-questions aimed at your present behaviour; they are accusations wearing grammar (T-06-04).

Drawn from: B5

Source dossiers for this entry are collected in the companion Source Dossiers volume.

Related: *The Automatic Response; Concession and Retreat; A Commitment You Did Not Choose*

Chapter 15

The Appeals

Self-interest, fantasy, and the need to believe

15.1 The Crowd as Evidence T-15-01

What many people do is treated as proof that it is correct

CORE. People settle questions they cannot answer by looking at what other people are doing. The number doing it is read as evidence about the thing itself rather than as evidence about the number. Whoever controls the apparent number controls the conclusion.

MECHANISM. The inference is usually sound. If many people are doing something, they probably have information you do not, and following them is cheaper than investigating. That is why the shortcut persists: it is correct often enough to be worth keeping, and it is the only available answer to questions where personal expertise runs out.

The weakness is that the inference treats the crowd's behaviour as independent sampling. It almost never is. Each member is also

watching the others, so what looks like a hundred separate confirmations is frequently one uncertain person copied ninety-nine times. The evidence is not multiplied by the count; it is the same weak signal, repeated. Once that is seen, the technique is obvious: the number does not have to be produced by conviction, only displayed.

APPLICATION.

1. Make the number visible: queues, counts, testimonials, subscriptions, names. The display does the work; the substance does not have to match it.
2. Show the crowd rather than describing it. A witnessed number is worth several asserted ones.
3. Recruit a few people first and let the copying supply the rest.
4. Time the display to the moment of decision, when the counterpart has least capacity to investigate.

FEEDBACK.

- Your reason for believing something is how many people appear to believe it.
- The count is visible but the individuals behind it are not.
- Nobody you ask can say why they are doing it, only that everyone is.
- Dissent is absent rather than answered.
- The crowd appears at the moment a decision is needed and not before.

FAILURE MODES. Manufacturing a crowd is fragile and frequently discoverable. Once the display is known to be staged, everything

else you assert inherits the doubt, which is a much larger loss than the single transaction. It is also the technique most exposed to a simple question — why are you doing this? — because the answer is usually that everyone else is, and everyone else has the same answer.

COUNTERMEASURES.

- Ask how many of them decided independently. One source copied widely is not a consensus.
- Find the first person and ask them why. The chain usually terminates quickly, in someone with no more information than you.
- Compare against a base rate rather than against the display. What proportion of people normally do this?
- Look for the absent dissent. A crowd with no visible disagreement has usually had its disagreement removed.
- Decide privately before seeing the number, then treat any change in your view as a thing to explain.

Drawn from: B4

Source dossiers for this entry are collected in the companion Source Dossiers volume.

Related: *Uncertainty and Similarity; Manufactured Consensus; Reading a Seeded Room; The Automatic Response*

15.2 Uncertainty and Similarity T-15-02

The two conditions that switch the crowd on

CORE. Crowd evidence is not consulted evenly. It is followed hardest in two conditions: when the situation is ambiguous, and when the crowd is made of people like you. Either one raises compliance; together they raise it most.

MECHANISM. Ambiguity removes the alternative. Where the facts are clear a person can check them; where they are not, there is nothing to check against and other people's behaviour becomes the only available data. Urgency compounds this, because it removes the time in which ambiguity could be resolved — which is why a crowd is most influential in exactly the situations where it is least reliable.

Similarity supplies the relevance test. Other people's behaviour is informative about what someone like you should do, and uninformative about what anyone should do. A crowd of strangers is weak evidence; a crowd of peers is strong. This is why the technique is worked by manufacturing resemblance — accent, age, dress, occupation, background — rather than by manufacturing numbers alone, and why a single well-matched witness can outweigh a large unmatched crowd.

APPLICATION.

1. Create ambiguity before presenting the crowd: withhold the facts that would let the counterpart check independently.
2. Add time pressure so the ambiguity cannot be resolved by enquiry.
3. Match the witnesses to the counterpart. One similar person is worth several dissimilar ones.
4. Lead with resemblance and follow with numbers, in that order.

FEEDBACK.

- You cannot state the facts of the situation, only what others seem to think they are.
- A decision is required quickly and information is arriving slowly.
- The people being cited resemble you specifically — your age, your role, your circumstances.
- The resemblance is mentioned rather than incidental.
- Nobody is investigating; everyone is watching everyone else.

FAILURE MODES. Both conditions are also the normal conditions of ordinary life. Refusing to consult others when uncertain, or refusing to weight peer experience, produces a person who reinvents every judgement from nothing and gets many of them wrong. The usable rule is narrow: treat crowd evidence as weak exactly where the stakes are high and the ambiguity is manufactured — and notice that those two tend to arrive together.

COUNTERMEASURES.

- Reduce ambiguity first and consult the crowd second. Get the facts from a source the other party does not control, then decide.
- Buy time deliberately. Almost every crowd-driven decision improves overnight, and the pressure to decide now is itself a signal.
- Discount resemblance that is presented to you. A witness selected because they are like you was selected for that reason.
- Ask what the dissimilar people are doing. If only peers agree, the agreement may be a property of the peer group rather than of the question.

Drawn from: B4

Source dossiers for this entry are collected in the companion Source Dossiers volume.

Related: *The Crowd as Evidence; Manufactured Consensus; The Automatic Response; Reading a Seeded Room*

Chapter 16

Argument and Demonstration

Winning without winning the argument

16.1 Concession and Retreat T-16-01

A demand refused and then reduced gets more than the reduced demand alone

CORE. Open with a demand you expect refused, then withdraw it in favour of a smaller one. The smaller demand is granted at a rate it would not have achieved on its own, because the withdrawal is read as a concession and a concession invites one.

MECHANISM. Two principles combine and neither requires sincerity.

Reciprocity supplies the obligation: a move toward you creates a duty to move toward the other party, and reducing a demand is such a move whether or not the reduced demand was the intended one all along. Contrast supplies the calibration: the second

demand is judged against the first rather than on its own, so it arrives already looking moderate.

The important property is that both respond to the *form* of the move rather than to the intent behind it. Knowing the sequence is scripted does not switch either off, which is why the technique survives being recognised. What it purchases is not agreement with a position but a felt duty to meet a halfway point that was never halfway. A subscription pitched annually, declined, and replaced with a monthly one closes at a rate the monthly offer would not have closed had it been made first.

APPLICATION.

1. Open above your real target, and treat the opening as an instrument rather than as a position to be defended.
2. Retreat in one clear step. Several small reductions read as ordinary negotiation and lose the concession effect entirely.
3. Make the retreat visible and slightly costly-looking; a withdrawal that appears effortless invites no return.
4. Ask for the return in a different currency from the concession, so no direct comparison is available.

FEEDBACK.

- The opening demand is larger than the other party could have expected you to accept.
- It is withdrawn quickly and without visible reluctance.
- The replacement is presented as a compromise.
- You feel you gained something by refusing and cannot say what.
- Both demands serve the same interest, and the second was available from the start.

FAILURE MODES. The opener is exposed if the first demand is absurd, because an obviously planted anchor destroys the credibility of everything that follows — including the honest parts of the position. It also teaches the counterpart to read every later reduction as scripted, which removes its value in any negotiation that continues. Cheap once against a stranger; expensive repeatedly against someone you will meet again.

COUNTERMEASURES.

- Re-classify the move: ask whether the second demand is a concession or simply the offer, and evaluate it as though it had arrived first.
- Decline to reciprocate a retreat that costs the other party nothing. A reduction that leaves their interest intact was never a concession.
- Test it with a retreat of your own. Reduce your position slightly and see whether they reduce again; a conciliator will, a script will not.
- Slow the exchange down. The duty to answer a concession is strongest inside a single conversation.
- Ask for the reduced demand in writing, on its own, dated. Detached from the opener it usually loses most of its force.

Drawn from: B4

Source dossiers for this entry are collected in the companion Source Dossiers volume.

Related: *The Contrast Principle; The Uninvited Debt; Refusing an Unauthorised Debt; Doing Their Thinking* (planned)

16.2 The Summary That Gets “That’s Right” T-16-05

Felt agreement without conceding the argument

CORE. Restate the counterpart’s position so completely and accurately — their words, their reasons, their feelings — that they answer *that’s right*. In that moment they have agreed with you about their own situation, which is a real act of commitment bought without a single concession, and it opens movement that argument cannot.

MECHANISM. A summary combines paraphrase with a closing label. Its power is recognition: most people have never heard their own position stated back to them correctly, and the experience of being accurately heard produces the one answer the source treats as a milestone — *that’s right* — which is felt as internal agreement, not extracted compliance. The distinction does the diagnostic work: *you’re right* is the counterfeit, the phrase people use to end a conversation they have stopped engaging with. Commitment attaches to conclusions the person reaches; a summary makes your framing the occasion for their conclusion.

CONDITIONS. Strongest after a long or tangled statement of position, with emotional or stubborn counterparts, and any time agreement exists only as counterfeit yeses. Weak against a counterpart whose position is a rote script (nothing true left to reflect), in genuinely simple transactions where the ceremony wastes time, and against a counterpart who recognises therapy-style handling and resents it.

APPLICATION.

1. Collect the parts as they talk: their stated position, their reasons, and the emotion under it.

2. Deliver the whole picture back in one calm passage — their case, better organised than they made it, ending on their stake.
3. Close with a label of the feeling underneath it, then stop.
4. Wait for *that’s right*. Do not move before it arrives.
5. Only then introduce your ask — as the natural next step inside a world they have just agreed is accurately described.

FEEDBACK.

- Landing: *that’s right* — sometimes with visible relief; posture opens and the counterpart starts problem-solving aloud.
- Landing: they add the missing piece unprompted, correcting the summary toward their real constraint.
- Failing: *you’re right* — the conversation is over in their head; reopen with a mirror (T-07-04) or a label, not with your ask.
- Failing: corrections delivered flatly with no engagement. The summary missed the stake; re-run it on what they corrected.

FAILURE MODES. A summary that is technically complete but emotionally toneless buys nothing — accuracy without recognition reads as transcription. It can also hand over structure: a precise reflection of their position tells a sharp counterpart you have organised their case better than they have, and some will go quiet rather than be handled. And the milestone can be faked back — *that’s right* can be flattery from a counterpart running the same play.

COUNTERMEASURES.

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- Distinguish the two phrases in your own mouth. If you are saying *you're right* to end a conversation, notice what you just declined to engage with.
 - When someone summarises you accurately, you are half-agreed. Ask what they want before accepting the frame their summary implies.
 - Treat a too-perfect reflection as technique: answer its accuracy, then state your price for continuing — *that's right, and here is what I need*.
 - Beware your own relief at being heard; that relief is the moment influence is being bought.

Drawn from: B5

Source dossiers for this entry are collected in the companion Source Dossiers volume.

Related: *Doing Their Thinking* (planned); *The Mirror*; *Borrowed Warmth*

Chapter 17

Delivery

Timing, boldness and effortlessness

Entries in this chapter are not yet written. The scaffolding is in place; see the State of the Build appendix for what is outstanding.

Chapter 18

Appearance and Compliance

Looking like the thing you are not

18.1 The Symbols of Authority T-18-01

Deference is triggered by the sign of competence, not by competence

CORE. People obey authority, and they identify authority by its symbols — a title, a uniform, a setting, a manner. The symbols can be produced without the substance, and the response follows the symbols rather than checking for what they stand for.

MECHANISM. Deferring to genuine expertise is efficient and usually correct. Judging expertise directly requires knowing the field, which is precisely what you lack in the situations where expertise matters most. So a proxy is used, and the proxy is whatever is

externally visible: the credential, the confidence, the vocabulary, the institution, the equipment.

The proxy is the vulnerability. Visible signs of competence are cheaper to acquire than competence — a title can be assumed, a manner learned, a setting rented — and the cost gap is what the technique exploits. Two features make it worse. Deference is automatic: the response fires on the symbol before any evaluation occurs, so it is not experienced as a decision. And it is self-reinforcing, because having deferred once, reversing requires admitting the first deference was misplaced.

APPLICATION.

1. Acquire the visible markers of the field you want to be deferred to in: setting, vocabulary, dress, and a title that sounds institutional.
2. Present credentials early, before the request, so that the request arrives already inside a frame of deference.
3. Borrow authority rather than claiming it: an association with an institution or a name costs less and is harder to check.
4. Speak with the flat confidence of someone for whom the question is routine. Hesitation is read as absence of qualification.

FEEDBACK.

- You are complying because of who appears to be asking rather than because of what is being asked.
- The authority is asserted by its symbols and never by its results.

- You cannot say what the person is actually qualified to judge.
- Questioning them feels like insubordination rather than like enquiry.
- The setting, the title or the manner is doing more work than the content.

FAILURE MODES. Borrowed or assumed authority fails badly when tested, and the failure is public — which is why the technique is concentrated where verification is unlikely and the interaction is short. In many settings a claimed credential that does not exist is not merely deceptive but actionable. There is also a quieter cost: a person who habitually defers to symbols stops developing the judgement that would let them evaluate anything directly, and becomes permanently dependent on whoever arrives with the better markers.

COUNTERMEASURES.

- Ask two questions, in this order: is this person an expert, and is this expert telling me the truth here? The first is usually conceded; the second is where the leverage is.
- Establish the domain. Ask what specifically they are qualified to judge — credentials transfer poorly across fields and are frequently cited outside theirs.
- Ask what would change their mind. An expert has a view of the evidence; a symbol has a position.
- Check the incentive. Expertise that profits from your compliance is worth discounting even when it is real.
- Require the claim in a form you can verify later.

Drawn from: B4

Source dossiers for this entry are collected in the companion Source Dossiers volume.

Related: *Titles, Uniform and Trappings; Testing a Claimed Credential; The Automatic Response; Borrowed Warmth*

18.2 Titles, Uniform and Trappings T-18-02

The three costumes that are never checked

CORE. Three symbols do most of the work: a title, a uniform, and the trappings of position — the car, the office, the cut of the clothes. All three are detachable from the thing they signify, all three are cheap, and none of them is routinely verified.

MECHANISM. Each symbol answers a question that would otherwise take investigation, and each is answered in a form that discourages follow-up.

A title asserts rank and implies that the rank was conferred by someone competent to confer it. It is the most portable of the three because it requires no props — only that it be said and not contradicted, and that it be specific enough to sound earned. Titles borrowed from adjacent fields work best, since the audience recognises the vocabulary without being able to check the credential.

A uniform asserts institutional backing and transfers the institution's authority to the wearer for the duration of the contact. It is the most powerful and the easiest to acquire, because the garment is widely available and the response to it is trained from childhood.

Trappings assert success, and success is read as evidence of competence and of honesty — the assumption being that a person who has done well did not need to deceive. Trappings are rented

rather than owned, which makes them the cheapest of the three to fake and the hardest to disprove at the moment of contact.

APPLICATION.

1. Choose the title for its specificity and its adjacency to the field you need authority in.
2. Wear the institutional marker where the contact is brief and verification is impractical.
3. Rent the trappings for the occasion. The judgement is made in the first minutes and does not survive to be checked.
4. Introduce the symbol early, then let the request arrive inside the frame it sets.

FEEDBACK.

- A title is offered but its conferring institution is not, or is named vaguely.
- The uniform or the setting appears only for this contact and not on any other occasion.
- The trappings are visible but the source of them is never mentioned.
- The symbol is introduced before any substantive claim.
- Questioning the symbol produces offence rather than information.

FAILURE MODES. All three symbols are falsifiable and frequently falsified, so a person who relies on them is exposed the first time anyone checks. The uniform is the most dangerous of the three to misuse: wearing one you are not entitled to is a criminal offence in most jurisdictions, quite apart from whatever the contact itself

amounts to. And the habit of verifying nothing transfers to the verifier — someone who accepts symbols without checking becomes the reliable target that the technique is designed to find.

COUNTERMEASURES.

- Ask for the conferring body and verify it independently. A title that cannot name its source is a description, not a credential.
- Ask to see the credential rather than hearing about it — an identifier, a registration, a callback to a number you found yourself.
- Never use contact details supplied by the person claiming authority. Find the institution independently and call it.
- Discount trappings entirely. Success displayed to you was selected to be displayed.
- Introduce a delay. Uniforms, titles and rented settings are all designed for a single contact and decay badly over two days.

Drawn from: B4

Source dossiers for this entry are collected in the companion Source Dossiers volume.

Related: *The Symbols of Authority; Testing a Claimed Credential; Borrowed Warmth; A Reputation You Built on Purpose*

Part V

Pressure

Hard tactics. They work faster than anything in Part IV and cost more than everything in it. Every entry here carries an unusually long limits slot, because the bill for pressure arrives later and is paid in kind.

Chapter 19

Guilt, Fear and Obligation

The soft pressures

19.1 The Uninvited Debt T-19-01

An obligation does not require your consent

CORE. A benefit you never asked for, from someone you never chose, creates the same pressure to repay as one you negotiated — and usually more, because declining it reads as ingratitude rather than as a decision. Consent is not part of the mechanism.

MECHANISM. Reciprocity is enforced socially rather than contractually. The person who takes a benefit and returns nothing is marked, and the marking is public. That makes the rule hard to opt out of, because the opt-out is itself visible and is read as a verdict on character.

So the operative fact is not the value of the benefit but its occurrence. An unrequested favour installs an account whose balance was never agreed, whose repayment date is chosen by the creditor, and whose currency the creditor will nominate later. Critically, the repayment need have nothing to do with the original benefit: the account is not a trade, it is a standing obligation, and it can be drawn on for any request the holder likes to make. Choosing the form and timing of the benefit is what gives the holder control over the draw. A clipboard, a flower pressed into a hand, an audit offered free of charge: the benefit is chosen so that declining it in public costs more than accepting it.

APPLICATION.

1. Give first, on your own terms, and keep accounts small and closed; an open balance is an asset to whoever holds it.
2. Choose a benefit that is genuinely useful and unmistakably voluntary, so that its reality cannot later be disputed.
3. Decide the request you will make before the benefit is given, and make it in a different currency from the benefit.
4. Never name the debt. Naming converts an asset into a grievance and releases the other party from it.

FEEDBACK.

- A benefit arrives that you would have declined had you been asked.
- The giver chose its form, its size and its timing.
- The request that follows is unrelated to the benefit and larger than it.
- Refusing produces a feeling about yourself rather than a calculation about the transaction.

- The benefit is mentioned — by the giver or by a third party — shortly before the request.

FAILURE MODES. Refusing every unsolicited benefit produces a person who cannot accept help and reads all generosity as an opening move, which is its own captivity and costs real relationships. The rule worth holding is narrow: scrutinise where the benefit was unrequested, large relative to the relationship, or followed quickly by an unrelated ask. Elsewhere let the account stand — ordinary reciprocity is what makes cooperation affordable in the first place.

COUNTERMEASURES.

- Refuse early and politely, in the same breath as the offer. Once acceptance has been observed, the only remaining question is the size of the repayment, and the other party sets it.
- Where refusal is impossible, repay at once, specifically, and in a form you choose. A closed account cannot be drawn on.
- Split the two questions — *was I helped?* and *does this request follow from it?* — and answer the second on its own.
- Price the benefit at what it cost the giver, not at what it is worth to you.
- Make the refusal short and unexplained. A reason offered is a reason to be argued with.

Drawn from: B4

Source dossiers for this entry are collected in the companion Source Dossiers volume.

Related: *The Favour Debt; Unequal Exchange; Refusing an Unauthorised Debt; Concession and Retreat*

19.2 Unequal Exchange T-19-02

The repayment need not resemble the debt

CORE. A small benefit can be traded for a much larger one, and the trade usually goes through. The pressure generated is to repay, not to repay equally, and nothing in the mechanism sets an exchange rate.

MECHANISM. The account carries no stated amount and no stated currency, so the debtor settles it by reference to a feeling rather than to an arithmetic of equivalence. That leaves the size of the repayment to be proposed by the creditor, who has every reason to propose large.

Two forces reinforce the asymmetry. The first is discomfort: an unsettled account is unpleasant to hold, and the quickest way to be rid of the feeling is to agree to whatever is asked, which makes the yes a relief rather than a decision. The second is exposure: not reciprocating is publicly marked, so the debtor is not merely uncomfortable but visibly so, and even a lopsided repayment clears the marking. Because both forces respond to the fact of the debt and not to its size, the disproportion is never felt as a reason to refuse. A free sample is not a gift of product. It is the opening of an account whose intended repayment is a purchase, and whose size is set at the till rather than at the counter.

APPLICATION.

1. Keep the opening benefit small, cheap for you to give and visibly personal; the exchange rate is set by the feeling, not by the value.
2. Ask for the larger thing soon afterwards, and in a different currency, so that no comparison is available to the other party.

3. Leave the benefit unpriced. A benefit that has been costed has already been repaid.

FEEDBACK.

- The request is far larger than the benefit, and the disproportion goes unremarked.
- You experience owing a decision rather than owing a comparable favour.
- Agreeing relieves a feeling more than it achieves an outcome.
- The benefit was chosen by the other party and costs them little to give.
- No price was ever attached to the benefit, and attaching one now feels rude.

FAILURE MODES. Pushed too far the technique brands its user: a person known for trading small kindnesses into large concessions finds the marking that makes reciprocity work running against them, and later benefits are refused at the door. It also fails outright where the account is not meant to be settled at all — family, long colleagues — because proposing an exchange rate in such a relationship is itself the offence, and the offence outlasts the concession.

COUNTERMEASURES.

- Insist on the arithmetic. Establish what the benefit was worth, repay in kind and promptly, and treat the account as closed.
- Name the disproportion plainly and without accusation: this is considerably larger than what you did for me.

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- Delay. The discomfort driving the unequal exchange decays faster than the obligation itself.
 - Choose the repayment currency rather than accepting the one offered.
 - Ask what the benefit cost the giver. A cheap gift demanding an expensive return is a transaction, not a kindness, and can be treated as one.

Drawn from: B4

Source dossiers for this entry are collected in the companion Source Dossiers volume.

Related: *The Uninvited Debt; The Favour Debt; The Reneged Price; Refusing an Unauthorised Debt*

Chapter 20

Coercion and the Dirty Way

The hard pressures, and their price

Entries in this chapter are not yet written. The scaffolding is in place; see the State of the Build appendix for what is outstanding.

Chapter 21

Conflict

Enemies, surrender, retaliation

Entries in this chapter are not yet written. The scaffolding is in place; see the State of the Build appendix for what is outstanding.

Chapter 22

Working the Hearts

Seduction rather than force

22.1 The Liking Handle T-22-01

Agreement is bought more cheaply by being liked than by being right

CORE. People say yes to those they like, and the effect is large enough that liking can be manufactured more cheaply than a case can be argued. Five things produce it: resemblance, praise, familiarity built through working together, surface appeal, and association with good news.

MECHANISM. Liking is used as a shortcut for trustworthiness, on the reasonable assumption that someone who is like you, who approves of you, and whom you have cooperated with is unlikely to harm you. The assumption is sound about people you know. It is not sound about people who have studied the cues.

Each component can be produced independently of the quality it stands for. Resemblance is a matter of matching posture, vocabulary, pace and background, all of which are observable and

copyable. Praise requires only that it be pleasant to receive — and it remains pleasant when the recipient knows it is strategic. Familiarity is manufactured by arranging repeated small cooperation rather than by waiting for a relationship to develop. Surface appeal is dressing, grooming and setting. Association is attaching yourself to whatever the counterpart already likes. None of the five requires sincerity, and none is switched off by being recognised.

APPLICATION.

1. Establish resemblance before making the request: pace, vocabulary, and one genuine point of common background.
2. Praise specifically and early. Vague praise reads as technique; specific praise reads as attention.
3. Arrange a small cooperative task before the real negotiation, so that the relationship exists when the disagreement arrives.
4. Manage the setting and your own presentation; surface appeal is cheap and is weighted far above its information content.
5. Attach the proposal to something the counterpart already values rather than presenting it on its own.

FEEDBACK.

- You find the person agreeable and cannot say what they have actually agreed to.
- They resemble you in ways that became visible only after you met.
- They praise you early, specifically, and before asking anything.

- A small joint task is proposed before the real one.
- You are more willing to concede to them than the merits warrant.

FAILURE MODES. The components are visible to anyone who knows them, and a person caught manufacturing resemblance loses the credibility of everything genuine they had. It also degrades the practitioner: someone who habitually matches, praises and attaches themselves to good news eventually finds it hard to tell which of their own opinions are theirs, which is a real loss and is described in Part VII.

COUNTERMEASURES.

- Separate the person from the proposal. Ask whether you would accept the same terms from someone you found disagreeable.
- Discount resemblance that appeared after the meeting began. Matching is a technique; shared history is not.
- Receive praise and do not repay it. Being approved of creates an obligation to approve back, which is the point of it.
- Decline the small joint task, or complete it and then re-open the real question from scratch.
- Delay. Liking decays faster than a good argument, and the decision improves overnight.

Drawn from: B4

Source dossiers for this entry are collected in the companion Source Dossiers volume.

Related: *Borrowed Warmth; Manufactured Rapport; Vanity as a Handle; A Commitment You Did Not Choose*

22.2 Borrowed Warmth T-22-02

Attaching yourself to what is already liked

CORE. Regard transfers by contact. A person, product or proposal that appears alongside something already valued is valued more highly, and the transfer happens without any argument being made. The same mechanism runs in reverse, which is why people distance themselves from bad news they had no part in.

MECHANISM. The transfer works because association is one of the ways the mind economises on evaluation. Judging something on its merits requires information; judging it by what it is next to requires only attention. Where information is unavailable — which is most of the time — the second method is used and is experienced as the first.

This makes proximity a controllable variable rather than an accident. The messenger can be chosen for their warmth, the setting for its quality, the photograph for its company, and the announcement for its timing alongside good news. It also explains a consistent asymmetry: people claim connection with success and disclaim connection with failure, using first-person language for one and distant language for the other. That behaviour is the same mechanism observed from the other side, and it is a reliable diagnostic in itself.

APPLICATION.

1. Choose the messenger for the counterpart's regard, not for relevance.
2. Time the request to follow good news rather than precede it.
3. Place the proposal alongside something already valued — a shared cause, a respected name, a familiar setting.

4. Claim successes in the first person and describe failures distantly; both are read as evidence about you.

FEEDBACK.

- A proposal arrives attached to a name, a cause or an event you already approve of, and the connection is emphasised.
- The messenger was chosen for how you feel about them rather than for what they know.
- Good news and the request arrive together.
- Someone uses first-person language about a success they did not produce, and distant language about a failure they did.
- You like the proposal and cannot separate it from its company.

FAILURE MODES. Borrowed warmth is rented, not owned, and the rent comes due when the borrowed thing fails — at which point the discredit transfers back with the same mechanism that carried the credit. Building a position entirely out of association also leaves nothing standing when the associations are removed, which is a common failure in careers built on proximity rather than on output.

COUNTERMEASURES.

- Detach the proposal and evaluate it alone. Ask what it would look like presented by someone you distrust, in a plain room, on an ordinary day.
- Notice the messenger's selection. A person chosen for their warmth was chosen for a reason, and the reason is not their expertise.

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- Watch your own language about successes and failures. The asymmetry is the tell, in yourself as much as in others.
 - Separate the announcement from the timing. Ask what else happened that day.

Drawn from: B4

Source dossiers for this entry are collected in the companion Source Dossiers volume.

Related: *The Liking Handle; Vanity as a Handle; A Reputation You Built on Purpose; Manufactured Rapport*

Part VI

Defence

*The half of the book that pays for itself. Detection, refusal, money, exit.
A reader who is currently being worked on should start here and go
backwards.*

Chapter 23

Detection

Reading it live

23.1 Reading a Seeded Room T-23-01

Detecting consensus that has been assembled

CORE. A room in which everyone agrees is evidence of two possible things: that the proposition is true, or that the room was built. The two are distinguished by asking questions about the room rather than about the proposition.

MECHANISM. Direct evaluation of the claim is useless here, because the claim is not what has been engineered. What has been engineered is the distribution of visible agreement, so the diagnostic has to examine that distribution.

Genuine consensus has a particular shape. It is uneven — some people agree strongly, some weakly, some for different reasons. It is stable across venues and across time. It resolves into named individuals who can be contacted separately. And it tolerates

dissent, because people who hold a view for reasons do not need objections suppressed.

Assembled consensus fails most of those tests at once. It is unanimous, unexplained, synchronized in time, concentrated in a single venue, anonymous or newly created, and intolerant of disagreement. Any one of these is weak evidence; three together are strong.

APPLICATION.

1. Ask for names, then contact two of them separately and out of the venue.
2. Check the timestamps: when did agreement become visible, and did it arrive gradually or at once?
3. Take the same question to a room nobody built — a different audience, a different channel, a private conversation.
4. Ask what would have to be excluded for the room to look like this.
5. Look at the shape of the agreement. Uneven and reasoned is real; flat and unanimous is not.

FEEDBACK.

- Agreement is unanimous and nobody can give a reason for it.
- Support appeared at one moment rather than accumulating.
- The same voices appear in every venue where the view is held.
- Dissent is filtered out, or answered by other audience members.
- Supporters are anonymous, aggregated or recently created.

- You cannot name one holder of the view who is not part of the presentation.

FAILURE MODES. The diagnostic produces false positives on things that are merely popular. Fashion, convention and genuine majority opinion all look partly like assembled consensus, and treating every agreement as staged makes you unworkable and alone. The test is worth running where the stakes are high, where the agreement appeared suddenly, or where someone benefits from it — not as a general posture.

COUNTERMEASURES.

- When names are refused, treat the refusal as the answer rather than pursuing the claim.
- When the view is defended by other audience members, notice who is being protected — the presenter who does not answer is the one with the stake.
- When the timestamps are unavailable, ask why the history of the agreement is not visible.
- When your own dissent is treated as a problem to be corrected, agree that it is and leave; a room that cannot hold an objection was not built to hold information.

Drawn from: B4

Source dossiers for this entry are collected in the companion Source Dossiers volume.

Related: *Manufactured Consensus; The Crowd as Evidence; Uncertainty and Similarity; Manufactured Rapport*

23.2 Manufactured Rapport T-23-02

Detecting liking that has been assembled

CORE. Rapport that has been built to order shows a characteristic shape: it arrives fast, it is one-directional, it matches you specifically, and it is withdrawn when it stops being useful. Genuine rapport is slower, less flattering and survives disagreement.

MECHANISM. The detection works because manufactured liking is optimised rather than developed. It is produced to a specification — your vocabulary, your pace, your opinions, your background — and anything optimised to a target overshoots it. Real resemblance is partial and includes friction; matched resemblance is total and includes none.

Speed is the most reliable single signal. Familiarity takes time to accumulate, and warmth that arrives without the time has been supplied rather than earned. Direction is the second: manufactured rapport flows toward you and asks little in return, because its function is to lower your defences rather than to build a relationship. The third test is disagreement — introduce one, mildly. Rapport that survives a difference of opinion is probably real. Rapport that immediately re-matches you is not.

APPLICATION.

1. Introduce a mild disagreement and watch whether it is engaged or absorbed.
2. Change one of your own positions mid-conversation and see whether theirs follows.
3. Ask something personal and unrelated to the business; a manufactured relationship has no off-script material.
4. Delay the decision by a day and observe whether the warmth persists without progress.
5. Compare their manner toward you with their manner toward someone who cannot help them.

FEEDBACK.

- Warmth arrives in the first minutes rather than over weeks.
- The resemblance is comprehensive and includes your vocabulary, pace and opinions.
- They agree with you on matters where disagreement would cost them nothing.
- Praise is specific, early, and precedes any request.
- The warmth cools immediately after the decision is made.
- Nothing about them surprises you, which is unusual in a person you have just met.

FAILURE MODES. Run as a general posture this diagnostic is expensive: it makes ordinary friendliness suspicious and produces a person who cannot accept warmth without auditing it, which costs real relationships and eventually makes the suspicion self-confirming. It is worth running where there is a transaction pending, where the warmth arrived unusually fast, or where you have something the other party wants. Elsewhere let it pass.

COUNTERMEASURES.

- When they claim shared background, ask a specific question about it. Invented common ground does not survive detail.
- When praise arrives early, receive it neutrally and change the subject; do not reciprocate, since reciprocity is what is being purchased.
- When the warmth cools after the decision, note the timing rather than raising it — the pattern is the information and it will repeat.

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- When a mild disagreement is instantly absorbed, agree and re-open the substantive question separately.

Drawn from: B4

Source dossiers for this entry are collected in the companion Source Dossiers volume.

Related: *The Liking Handle; Borrowed Warmth; Reading a Seeded Room; Vanity as a Handle*

23.3 Testing a Claimed Credential T-23-03

Verification that does not depend on the person being verified

CORE. A credential is worth exactly as much as your ability to check it without the claimant's help. Any verification that runs through the person claiming authority — their number, their reference, their colleague — verifies nothing at all.

MECHANISM. The failure mode is circular. A claimed authority offers the means of checking the claim, the means are controlled by the claimant, and the check confirms whatever was asserted. The circle is invisible in the moment because the check feels like diligence.

Breaking it requires finding a route to the institution that does not pass through the individual: a number looked up independently, a registry searched by name, a colleague contacted through a switchboard rather than a mobile. Where no such route exists, the honest conclusion is that the credential is unverifiable — which is a usable finding, not a failure. Unverifiable authority should be treated as absent rather than as presumed.

A second test is available and costs nothing: ask for the claimant's reasoning rather than their conclusion. Genuine expertise can

show its work, including what would change it. A symbol repeats the position, becomes irritated at the question, or refers back to the credential itself.

APPLICATION.

1. Establish a route to the institution before making contact, so that the check does not have to be negotiated later.
2. Ask for reasoning rather than conclusions; it is cheap and it separates the two cases quickly.
3. Ask what would change their mind, and note whether the answer is about evidence or about loyalty.
4. Where the credential is unverifiable, say so plainly and proceed as though it were absent.

FEEDBACK.

- You are being asked to verify through channels the claimant supplied.
- The credential is asserted more often than it is evidenced.
- Questions about reasoning are answered with questions about your qualifications to ask.
- The claim is time-sensitive, which removes the opportunity to check.
- The title is specific but the conferring body is vague.

FAILURE MODES. Verification is slow, occasionally rude, and frequently unnecessary — most claimed authority is genuine, and checking all of it makes ordinary life unworkable. The test is therefore targeted: run it where money, consent, medical treatment, legal position or access is at stake, where the contact is

unusual in arriving, or where urgency is asserted. Elsewhere accept the symbol and move on.

COUNTERMEASURES.

- Look the institution up yourself. Do not use any number, address or contact given to you.
- Call back through a switchboard and ask for the person by name. A real employee is reachable that way; a costume is not.
- Search a public registry. Most regulated professions maintain one and most claimants assume you will not.
- Delay the decision by a day. Urgency is the one condition under which verification becomes impractical, and it is usually manufactured for that reason.
- Ask the question in writing. A claim that survives speech often does not survive being written down and dated.

Drawn from: B4

Source dossiers for this entry are collected in the companion Source Dossiers volume.

Related: *The Symbols of Authority; Titles, Uniform and Trappings; Reading a Seeded Room; Refusing a Deadline*

Chapter 24

Inoculation and Refusal

Answers that do not require winning

24.1 Refusing an Unauthorised Debt T-24-01

Declining the premise rather than arguing the amount

CORE. The answer to an obligation you did not create is not to argue that you owe nothing. It is to decline the premise on which the obligation was built — promptly, politely, and without engaging the merits of the request that follows it.

MECHANISM. Arguing about the size of a debt concedes that a debt exists. The obligation is installed by the occurrence of a benefit rather than by its value, so any discussion of value takes place inside the frame the other party built and can only ever adjust the amount.

What removes the frame is a decision taken before the request arrives: that an unrequested benefit opens no account. That decision is easy to hold and hard to execute, because the pressure

is social and visible, and refusing looks like ingratitude to any audience. The refusal therefore has two halves — an internal reclassification, and an external form of words that does not turn the refusal into a verdict on the giver's character. Where the benefit genuinely cannot be refused, only the second half changes: repay it immediately, specifically, and in a currency of your own choosing, so that nothing remains outstanding to be drawn on later.

APPLICATION.

1. Decide the policy in advance, so that the decision is not made under pressure in front of an audience.
2. Decline in the same breath as the offer, before acceptance has been seen by anyone.
3. Where decline is impossible, repay at once, name the amount, and state that the account is closed.
4. Answer the request separately and explicitly: these are two questions, and the first does not settle the second.
5. Keep the refusal short, warm and unexplained.

FEEDBACK.

- A benefit you did not request has arrived, and the giver chose its form and timing.
- A request follows that has no connection to the benefit.
- You are aware of feeling obliged before you have decided anything.
- Refusing would be observed by a third party.
- The benefit is referred to in the same conversation as the request.

FAILURE MODES. A refusal that is habitually applied makes you difficult to help, and people stop offering — which removes the ordinary goodwill that most relationships run on. The policy is therefore situational rather than absolute: it is aimed at benefits that were unrequested, chosen by the giver, and followed quickly by an unrelated ask. Applied to genuine kindness it produces a person who is defended against nothing and isolated by the defence.

COUNTERMEASURES.

- When the refusal is called ungrateful, agree that you are grateful and decline anyway. Gratitude and compliance are different things and can be stated separately.
- When the benefit is re-described as something you wanted, do not dispute the description; restate that you did not ask for it.
- When a third party applies the pressure, address them rather than the giver: the account, if there is one, is not theirs to collect.
- When the request is reduced after your refusal, treat the reduction as a new proposal and evaluate it on its own — see T-16-01.
- When you are offered a way to repay, take it, pay it in full, and consider the matter finished rather than continuing to negotiate.

Drawn from: B4

Source dossiers for this entry are collected in the companion Source Dossiers volume.

Related: *The Uninvited Debt; Unequal Exchange; Concession and Retreat; The Favour Debt*

24.2 A Commitment You Did Not Choose

T-24-02

Recognising the position that was installed rather than decided

CORE. The defence against manufactured consistency is not to resist the later request. It is to notice that the position you are defending was installed by a sequence rather than reached by a judgement, and to reopen the judgement on the current facts alone.

MECHANISM. Consistency feels like integrity, which is why it is rarely examined. A person asked to reverse does not usually weigh the question again; they experience the request as an attack on their character and defend the position for that reason. The defence is therefore aimed at the feeling rather than at the argument.

Two moves do most of the work. The first is to distinguish reasons that existed before the commitment from reasons that appeared after it, since the second group is largely manufactured by the commitment itself. The second is to permit reversal explicitly: changing your mind on new information is a different act from being inconsistent, and the distinction has to be made consciously because the social pressure does not make it for you.

APPLICATION.

1. Ask when you took the position, and what the grounds were at that moment.
2. List the reasons you hold it now, and mark which ones existed then.
3. Remove the audience. Decide privately first and announce afterwards, so that identity is not part of the calculation.

4. Reopen the question on current terms only, as though the earlier agreement had never happened.
5. Say out loud that changing your mind on new information is not inconsistency.

FEEDBACK.

- You are defending a position you cannot date — you do not remember deciding it.
- Your reasons have multiplied since you agreed.
- Reversing feels like an admission about you rather than a calculation about the question.
- The original inducement has been withdrawn and the position survived it.
- You would not advise a friend to hold the position on these terms.

FAILURE MODES. Reopening every position produces a person who cannot be relied on, and reliability is worth more than correctness in most ongoing relationships. The defence is therefore targeted rather than general: it applies where the position was installed by someone else's sequence, where the grounds have been withdrawn, or where the terms have moved. Positions genuinely reasoned through should be held, and held visibly, because that is what makes the other reversals credible.

COUNTERMEASURES.

- When reversal is called weakness, agree that the position has changed and decline to defend the change; the accusation only works if you accept that consistency is what is being tested.

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- When the original inducement is denied, do not argue about it — note that it is no longer present and that the position was built on it.
 - When others invoke your earlier statement, address the question rather than the record: what is being asked now, and would I agree to it today?
 - When the cost of reversing is presented as forfeiting what you have invested, treat the investment as spent and decide on what remains.

Drawn from: B4

Source dossiers for this entry are collected in the companion Source Dossiers volume.

Related: *The Small First Yes; The Four Amplifiers; The Reneged Price; Behaviour Over Declaration*

24.3 Refusing a Deadline T-24-03

Removing the pressure without refusing the offer

CORE. The answer to manufactured urgency is not to decline the offer. It is to decline the clock — to keep the question open while removing the condition that makes a bad decision likely.

MECHANISM. A deadline does not change what is on offer. It changes the conditions under which you evaluate it, and specifically it removes the ordinary remedy for a difficult judgement, which is to wait for more information. Under time pressure the mind falls back on shortcuts, and shortcuts are what the other party has arranged.

So the target of the defence is the clock rather than the proposal. This has a practical advantage: refusing an offer invites argument

about the offer, where the other party is better prepared, while refusing the clock invites argument about timing, where you are stronger and they have less at stake. It also keeps the relationship intact, because nothing has been declined.

The test of a manufactured deadline is what happens when it is ignored. A real constraint produces a consequence; a manufactured one produces a new deadline.

APPLICATION.

1. Acknowledge the offer and decline the timing, in the same sentence, without explaining.
2. Ask what changes if you decide tomorrow. The answer distinguishes a constraint from a device.
3. Request the terms in writing with the deadline stated, dated.
4. Offer a smaller commitment now and a real decision later, which concedes something without conceding the clock.
5. Move the conversation to a channel where the pressure does not apply — in writing, or with a third party present.

FEEDBACK.

- A date or quantity is stated with precision and no reason.
- The urgency appeared with the request rather than before it.
- You are being asked to decide faster than you would normally decide something of this size.
- Postponement is described as losing the offer rather than as delaying it.
- The same deadline has been announced before.

FAILURE MODES. Some deadlines are real, and treating all of them as devices costs genuine opportunities — a price that moves, a place that fills, a decision someone else will make for you. The defence is therefore calibrated rather than absolute: ask what changes tomorrow, weigh the answer, and accept that occasionally the honest response is to lose the offer. The asymmetry favours caution, because a missed opportunity is usually recoverable and a bad commitment rarely is.

COUNTERMEASURES.

- When the deadline is restated more loudly, treat the restatement as information: a real constraint does not need to be repeated.
- When postponement is called indecision, agree and postpone anyway. The charge costs nothing if you do not accept that speed is the virtue being tested.
- When a discount is offered for deciding now, price it against the value of deciding well rather than against the offer.
- When scarcity is added to the deadline, handle each separately — see T-10-03 — since answering both at once usually means answering neither.
- When the deadline passes and the offer stands, note it and discount every subsequent deadline from the same source.

Drawn from: B4

Source dossiers for this entry are collected in the companion Source Dossiers volume.

Related: *Value as a Function of Availability; Limited Numbers and Deadlines; Refusing an Unauthorised Debt; A Commitment You Did Not Choose*

24.4 The Safety of No T-24-05

Autonomy lives in the negative — so design asks that are safe to refuse

CORE. Pushing a counterpart toward *yes* triggers defence: every funnel-to-yes script works by closing escape routes, and people feel the cage. Offering a legitimate way to say *no* restores their sense of control, lowers the guard, and paradoxically makes engagement more likely. Refusal is not the opposite of agreement; it is the precondition of honest agreement.

MECHANISM. Saying no feels protective: it is the moment the counterpart stops being moved and starts being in charge, so a request framed to permit refusal removes the threat that drives resistance. The yes-funnel inverts this — a scripted flowchart of small commitments with no exit — and produces either a cornered refusal or a counterfeit yes given only to end the pressure. No-oriented questions reverse the dynamic: asked *is now a bad time?* or *have you given up on this project?*, the counterpart says no to the framing while moving toward the substance, and the movement is theirs.

CONDITIONS. Strongest with wary counterparts, early contact, and any interaction where the other side has been yes-pestered before and arrives pre-defended. Weakest when the matter is genuinely urgent and unambiguous — an emergency consent structure cannot afford a round-trip — and with counterparts who take an offered no as a door to exit permanently; the invitation must be honest or it reads as a trap the second time.

APPLICATION.

1. Frame the opening question so *no* is a safe, dignified answer: *is now a bad time?* beats *do you have a few minutes?* with guarded people.

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2. When contact goes dead, send the one-line revival: *have you given up on this project?* A no reopens it.
 3. Engineer the first no on something small and real, so the counterpart exercises refusal without cost.
 4. Never trap a yes. Leave the exit visible on purpose; say *no is fine* and mean it once, and the next answer is cheaper.
 5. If you are being funneled — small questions, escalating stakes, exits closing — break the script: say no to the smallest question retroactively and watch it collapse.

FEEDBACK.

- Landing: tension drops visibly after the refusal is made safe; the counterpart volunteers constraints they had been holding.
- Landing on the revival line: a fast, almost indignant no — which is engagement, not rejection.
- Failing: the counterpart takes the no and leaves; the invitation was real but there was nothing behind the door.
- Failing: repeated yes-funnel questions from them after you invited refusal — they want the cage, not the deal.

FAILURE MODES. Offered dishonestly, a no-invitation is a closer's trick; the counterpart learns your exits are decorative. An early genuine no can also harden into a position — refusal is sticky once spoken as identity rather than as schedule. And it buys an honest negotiation, not a good outcome; stacked on a weak offer it wastes time politely.

COUNTERMEASURES.

- Recognise the funnel: a chain of trivial yeses with exits quietly closing. Refuse one small item early and the funnel has nothing to stand on.
- Beware the mirrored trick: a no-invitation can itself be the funnel. Ask what happens after you say no — a real exit survives the question.
- Treat your own discomfort with saying no as the lever it is; the reason the technique works on you is that refusal feels costly.
- Confirm agreement only after an honest option to refuse existed, or the yes is worthless (T-24-02).

Drawn from: B5

Source dossiers for this entry are collected in the companion Source Dossiers volume.

Related: *A Commitment You Did Not Choose; The Automatic Response*

Chapter 25

Money and Contracts

Where the losses actually happen

25.1 The Reneged Price T-25-01

The terms change after the decision is made, and the decision survives

CORE. Secure the decision on attractive terms, then reveal that the terms were wrong. The decision frequently stands anyway, on terms nobody would have accepted at the outset. The gap between the offer that produced the yes and the offer that is actually delivered is the profit.

MECHANISM. The technique works because a decision, once made, is not continuously re-evaluated against its original grounds.

Commitment supplies its own support: the person has already begun assembling reasons, imagining the outcome and describing themselves as someone who does this thing. Those reasons are attached to the decision rather than to the price, so when the price moves the reasons stay.

Two conditions make it reliable. The change must arrive after the decision and not before it, so that it presents as an unfortunate discovery rather than as the actual offer. And it must be small enough to fall inside the range the person can absorb without reopening the whole question — which is a range set by how much they have already invested, and grows with it.

APPLICATION.

1. Present the attractive terms first and let the decision be taken on them.
2. Reveal the correction after signature, deposit or delivery, not before.
3. Keep the revision inside the range the counterpart can absorb without restarting, and frame it as a discovery you both share.
4. Offer a small concession alongside the correction so that the exchange still looks reciprocal.

FEEDBACK.

- The terms deteriorate after you have agreed and not before.
- The deterioration is presented as an error, an oversight or an unavoidable change rather than as a revision.
- You find yourself accepting terms you would have refused at the outset.
- The change is small relative to what you have already invested.
- Nobody offers to undo the decision along with the terms.

FAILURE MODES. This is the entry in the book most likely to be actionable rather than merely unpleasant: a material term

changed after agreement is in many jurisdictions misrepresentation, and the written record that makes the technique work is the same record that proves it. Commercially it also burns the customer — the transaction succeeds and the relationship does not, which is a bad trade in any market with repeat business or referrals.

COUNTERMEASURES.

- Make the decision conditional on the terms in writing, so that a change in terms is visibly a change in the decision's grounds.
- When the price moves, restart the decision rather than adjusting it. Ask whether you would buy this, at this, having not already bought anything.
- Pay nothing before the terms are fixed, and treat any deposit as the point at which your own judgement starts being used against you.
- Name the pattern plainly. It loses most of its force the moment both parties agree that is what is happening.
- Compare against the market rather than against the original offer, which is a comparison you no longer control.

Drawn from: B4

Source dossiers for this entry are collected in the companion Source Dossiers volume.

Related: *The Small First Yes; The Four Amplifiers; A Commitment You Did Not Choose; Unequal Exchange*

25.2 The Anchor T-25-03

First numbers bend the reality of the price

CORE. The first number or framing on the table becomes the reference the whole bargain is measured against — people judge outcomes as gains or losses from wherever the conversation starts, and losses loom roughly twice as large as gains. Who sets that starting point, and how, quietly decides the range in which the deal lands.

MECHANISM. Loss aversion: the pain of losing is felt at about twice the intensity of an equivalent gain, so a counterpart shown a plausible loss will move to avoid it more eagerly than to secure a gain. Anchoring works the same ground: the first salient number drags every later judgment toward itself even when it is arbitrary. The source adds an emotional anchor — open by naming their fears (an accusation audit), which prices the loss before any number appears — and a semantic one: the word *fair*, used to pressure (*we just want a fair deal*), to accuse (*that's not fair*), or to establish the legitimate frame. Compromise itself is a price: splitting the difference feels principled and lands wherever the anchors put the midpoint.

CONDITIONS. Strongest in price-setting, salary and terms, hostage trades — anywhere a number or term is explicit and the counterpart cares about the reference. Weakens where the counterpart has solid market data (anchor against data), in repeated games where an extreme anchor costs reputation across rounds, and with counterparts trained to treat first numbers as artefacts.

APPLICATION.

1. Before any number, anchor the emotions: name the losses they fear, so the eventual ask reads as relief.
2. Let them go first when you are uncertain of the range; when you do go first, go with a defensible extreme, not a rude one.
3. Prefer a range to a point — recall a similar deal to set the best believable ballpark, aiming the top of it at your real target.

4. Use precise, odd figures: they signal calculation, and calculation reads as a real limit.
5. Refuse the mid-point reflex. If their anchor is absurd, re-anchor with reasons rather than countering from it.

FEEDBACK.

- Landing: their counter lands closer to your anchor than your opener; the negotiation is happening inside your range.
- Landing: they start justifying against your number — the anchor is doing the work.
- Failing: they ignore your number entirely and restate theirs; the anchor did not take.
- Failing: *fair* deployed mid-negotiation with sudden moral energy — an attempt to re-anchor the frame; answer it, never absorb it.

FAILURE MODES. An indefensible extreme is read as bad faith and costs the credibility the rest of the negotiation runs on. Anchoring someone against their will in a relationship transaction converts a price talk into a trust talk. And the mirror risk: every anchor you set teaches the counterpart your real position; a counterpart who anchors you first has priced your expectations for the next three rounds.

COUNTERMEASURES.

- Refuse to negotiate inside an absurd anchor: name it, restate your basis, make them move first.
- Carry independent data. The only reliable antidote to a number is another number with a source.

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- Hear *fair* as a move, not a moral claim: ask exactly what fairness requires here, and who defined it.
 - Notice the loss-framing around you — *you're about to lose this* is a price, not a fact (T-15-02).
 - Splitting the difference is not neutrality; it is the midpoint of two anchors.

Drawn from: B5

Source dossiers for this entry are collected in the companion Source Dossiers volume.

Related: *The Reneged Price; The Ackerman Plan; The Contrast Principle*

25.3 The Ackerman Plan T-25-04

A price ladder that ends on a number that looks calculated

CORE. A four-step haggle: set the target privately, open at 65 per cent of it, raise through 85 and 95 to 100, and close on a precise, non-round number plus a small non-monetary item. The shrinking raises read as approaching a real limit, and the odd final figure reads as calculation — so the endpoint lands as a derived fact rather than a position.

MECHANISM. The system beats the default haggle outcome, meeting in the middle — a midpoint that, as T-25-03 shows, is the average of two anchors. Each part does one job. The 65 per cent opener leaves four moves of room while staying inside the defensible extreme. The decreasing increments — twenty points, then ten, then five — make the counterpart read a curve approaching a wall: each raise costs the raiser visibly more, so the next one is presumed to be the last. Between raises, empathy and varied forms of *no* force the counterpart to counter first, so the ladder never climbs unopposed. The precise final number —

37,893, not 38,000 — borrows the credibility of calculation: round numbers are chosen, odd numbers are derived. The throw-in, a non-monetary item they probably do not want, signals the absolute limit.

CONDITIONS. Strongest in one-shot, single-issue price talks — purchases, salary, settlement — where the counterpart has no data advantage and no ongoing relationship to price the ladder against. Weakens against a counterpart who knows the system (the curve becomes legible and steerable), in repeated dealings where an extreme opener taxes your reputation in every later round, and whenever the target itself is a guess: the percentages then measure nothing. Power asymmetry can collapse the ladder — sometimes there is no fourth step.

APPLICATION.

1. Fix the target from outside data before contact, and write it down.
2. Open at 65 per cent — the defensible extreme of your real position.
3. Absorb counters with labels and no-oriented questions (T-24-05); never raise first.
4. Raise 85, then 95, then 100 — visibly pained, and spaced so each reads as extracted, not offered.
5. End on a precise non-round figure inside your target, add the throw-in you can afford, and stop talking.

FEEDBACK.

- Working: they keep countering between your steps — the ladder is being climbed jointly.
- Working: their offers approach your target while yours are still below 95.

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- Off-track: they accept before your third raise — the ladder was too shallow and money was left.
 - Off-track: stalemate at your 95. Hold; the next move is theirs, and taking it for them is bidding against yourself.

FAILURE MODES. Against a counterpart who recognises the curve, every rung signals your target rather than concedes; the system hands over its steering. Run eagerly — fast, unopposed raises — it signals room and invites compression. An unresearched target makes the whole ladder theatre. And the throw-in misfires both ways: read as insult it sours the end-state, read as theatre it confirms that the number was performance all along.

COUNTERMEASURES.

- Name the curve when you see it: decreasing raises are a system, not exhaustion. Say so, and the system spends itself.
- Demand a reason with each raise. A ladder is justified rung by rung or it is exposed.
- Stop moving. A ladder needs your counters; one firm restatement and a silence starves it.
- Write your own walk-away before contact. The ladder's real payload is the anchor it installs in you (T-25-03).

Drawn from: B5

Source dossiers for this entry are collected in the companion Source Dossiers volume.

Related: *The Anchor*; *The Reneged Price*; *The Safety of No*

Chapter 26

Exit and Aftermath

Disengaging cleanly

Entries in this chapter are not yet written. The scaffolding is in place; see the State of the Build appendix for what is outstanding.

Part VII

Cost

What the practice does to the practitioner, and what self-command is required before any of it is worth attempting.

Chapter 27

What You Get Out of Using People

The bill

Entries in this chapter are not yet written. The scaffolding is in place; see the State of the Build appendix for what is outstanding.

Chapter 28

Self-Mastery

The precondition

Entries in this chapter are not yet written. The scaffolding is in place; see the State of the Build appendix for what is outstanding.

Appendix A

State of the Build

Appendix B

State of the Build

This book is written incrementally, one entry at a time. The table below is generated, so it always tells the truth about what is finished and what is still scaffolding.

Published: **63** In draft: **0** Planned: **14** Sources ingested: **5**

The Terrain

- **What Manipulation Actually Is** — •T-01-01 [B1,B3,B4];
•T-01-02 [B1,B3,B4]; •T-01-03 [B3]; •T-01-04 [B1,B2];
•T-01-05 [B1,B3]
- **The Practitioner's Equipment** — •T-02-01 [B3]; •T-02-02 [B1,B3]; •T-02-03 [B3]; •T-02-04 [B3]; •T-02-05 [B1]
- **Character Types** — •T-03-01 [B3]; •T-03-02 [B1]
- **Load-Bearing Points** — •T-04-01 [B3]; •T-04-02 [B1,B3,B4];
•T-04-03 [B3,B1,B4]; •T-04-04 [B1,B3]

Reading

- **Motives Before Words** — •T-05-01 [B1]; •T-05-02 [B1,B3];
•T-05-03 [B5]
- **Tells and Consistency** — •T-06-01 [B1]; •T-06-02 [B1];
•T-06-03 [B1]; •T-06-04 [B1,B3,B4]; •T-06-05 [B5]
- **Gathering Information** — •T-07-01 [B3,B5]; •T-07-02
[B3,B1]; •T-07-03 [B1]; •T-07-04 [B5]
- **Judging Who You Are Dealing With** — •T-08-01 [B3];
•T-08-02 [B1,B3]

Positioning

- **Reputation** — •T-09-01 [B3]; •T-09-02 [B3]; •T-09-03 [B3]
- **Attention, Absence and Scarcity** — •T-10-01 [B4];
•T-10-02 [B4]; •T-10-03 [B4]
- **Dependence** — •T-11-01 [B1,B3]
- **Alliances, Patrons and Courts** — *no entries yet*
- **Concealment and Indirection** — •T-13-01 [B4]; •T-13-02
[B1]; •T-13-04 [B3]

Persuasion

- **Framing and Controlled Choice** — •T-14-01 [B4,B5];
•T-14-02 [B4]; •T-14-03 [B4]; •T-14-04 [B4]; •T-14-07 [B5];
•T-14-08 [B5]
- **The Appeals** — •T-15-01 [B4]; •T-15-02 [B4]
- **Argument and Demonstration** — •T-16-01 [B4]; •T-16-02
[B1]; •T-16-03 [B1]; •T-16-05 [B5]
- **Delivery** — •T-17-01 [B3]; •T-17-02 [B3]
- **Appearance and Compliance** — •T-18-01 [B4]; •T-18-02
[B4]; •T-18-04 [B3]

Pressure

- **Guilt, Fear and Obligation** — •T-19-01 [B4]; •T-19-02 [B4]
- **Coercion and the Dirty Way** — *no entries yet*
- **Conflict** — ·T-21-01 [B3]; ·T-21-02 [B3]; ·T-21-03 [B3]
- **Working the Hearts** — •T-22-01 [B4]; •T-22-02 [B4]

Defence

- **Detection** — •T-23-01 [B4]; •T-23-02 [B4]; •T-23-03 [B4]
- **Inoculation and Refusal** — •T-24-01 [B4]; •T-24-02 [B4];
•T-24-03 [B4]; •T-24-05 [B5]
- **Money and Contracts** — •T-25-01 [B4]; ·T-25-02 [B3];
•T-25-03 [B5]; •T-25-04 [B5]
- **Exit and Aftermath** — ·T-26-02 [B1]

Cost

- **What You Get Out of Using People** — ·T-27-01 [B1]
 - **Self-Mastery** — *no entries yet*
- published ◦ draft · planned scaffolding

Colophon

What this repository is. A book whose body is a few hundred small L^AT_EX files, and whose build system is written so that adding a fourth, fifth or fortieth source cannot damage the first three. The reading order is generated from the metadata header of each file, so no index is ever hand-maintained and no file is ever edited merely to make room for another.

The two layers. `topics/` holds the book: one idea per file, fixed slot structure, curated synthesis. `sources/` holds the evidence: one file per source per entry, append-only, never rewritten, with the material found in only one source explicitly flagged. A flagged contribution cannot be dropped from an entry — the build fails if anyone tries. That is the mechanism by which an early source survives a later one being better on the same subject.

Why the files are small. Quality degrades with length, in human and in machine writing alike. Repetition arrives, the voice drifts, and material already written gets paraphrased back at itself. An entry that will not fit in 700 words is two entries, and splitting it is cheaper than repairing the drift afterwards.

The rules. `docs/RULES.md` is the constitution and is versioned. `AGENTS.md` is the short form for automated writers. `tools/validate.py` enforces the machine-checkable subset; `tools/churn_guard.py` enforces the no-wholesale-rewrite rule against git history. Nothing important is left to memory.

State of the build. This edition contains Parts I and II in full and the scaffolding for Parts III to VII. The outstanding work is itemised in the

preceding appendix and in `registry/coverage.md`, both generated, so neither can disagree with the book.

Typesetting. `style/handbook.cls` and `style/entry.sty` hold every visual decision, and load each optional package behind a conditional so that the book compiles on a bare T_EX Live installation. No content file contains a layout command. To change how the book looks, change those two files.